Virtual Angel

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Virtual Angel

by starsenvy

Summary

Just as before, once Phainon turned his back, the computer powered back up and bright flickers of light filled the bedroom. This time, however, a small, invisible figure appeared, outlined only by the golden rays.

It was almost as if something was *alive* inside there.

Or; wherein a pixelated "golden fairy" takes over Mydei’s computer.

Chapter 1: Prologue - Hidden Secret

The following account has been suspended: DawnMaker496

“Oh for the love of—you've got to be kidding me!”

Phainon slumped down into his desk chair, utterly defeated. All he wanted to do after a long day of work and running around the holy city doing errands for Aglaea was to sit down, relax and shut off his brain with a group session on *Trash King Quest Online.* As far as he knew, Mydei, Cipher and Hyacine were already zipping around their little virtual world gathering resources for the journey ahead.

Phainon, being the gallant Deliverer and designated team leader, was supposed to lead his people into battle every Thursday evening right at the start of the Curtain Fall Hour. But there he was—stranded on his own without his companions. Nevermind the fact that he was the one holding all the maps, or that Mydei always tried to fight enemies that were twenty levels ahead of him, or that Hyacine’s spellcasting was locked at 50% efficiency, or even the fact that Cipher ran away to go treasure hunting all the time.

None of that mattered anymore. Phainon’s account was gone for good and he would have to start over from scratch. Hundreds of hours poured straight down the drain without even a solid explanation for his suspension. Of all things, it was just another instance of “suspicious activity” that would put his whole MMORPG career six feet under.

Really, this scenario was nothing new or shocking, but it still came as a huge letdown. This had become enough of a common occurrence that Phainon no longer fretted over the specifics of the suspension and immediately sank into an exasperated state of depression.

Perhaps if the situation had been any different he would have put up more of a fight. Maybe he would have panic-spammed the tech support email for answers, or frantically called up his local electronics store for an emergency diagnostics report on his computer. Maybe he would have even started searching for a brand new, completely reliable computer by now—nevermind the fact that he was still drowning in debt from his “impressively prolonged” undergraduate career, as Professor Anaxa would put it. But after reaching his breaking point ages ago, Phainon had nearly been numbed to the pain of loss. Specifically, the loss of nearly every single online gaming account he had created throughout the entire twenty-five year span of his life.

Still—he had worked so hard this time! All those grueling hours spent farming for materials, countless side quests to the highest mountain peaks searching for SSS-Rank weapons, all the bartering he had to do for the rarest armor sets in the game, including the legendary Gilded Worldbearer’s Garb, all gone in an instant…

If he wasn’t burdening his team with his absence, perhaps he would have shrugged it off. “Well, at least it wasn't my email that got hacked,” was all Phainon said each time before. And then he moved on to the next game, always searching for a new casual thrill to pass his time off. All Phainon could do now was stare up at the cracks in his ceiling and let out a tortured moan like a wraith.

“Seriously,” he muttered under his breath, willing the damning verdict burned into his monitor to disappear. “They’re never going to let me forget this. I’m officially the world's lousiest TKQ player of all time. I’m so bad at the game, they terminated my account.”

After another two quints’ worth of grumbling, Phainon finally shut down his computer and threw himself onto his bed (which was probably a mistake, given that it was a tiny single he’d had since childhood and he never bothered to replace the old springs in his mattress). His previously folded socks and linens went tumbling onto the floor in a sad, shapeless lump. When he finally bothered to check his teleslate, there were over twenty new messages awaiting him.

Team K.A.N.Z

TKQ Thursdays! Don’t forget!

Mydei: Phainon.

Mydei: You’re late. Again.

Hyacine: Oh dear. Maybe he just ran into traffic on the way home!

Mydei: This man cannot even drive, Hyacine.

Cipher: Ha! Maybe his little tricycle hit a rock and he went tumbling!

Cipher: Poor little Deliverer~

Cipher: ⸸ (•̀ω•́)⊸. ˖ ⊹ . ˖ . ⋆ . ˚ ☆

Hyacine: Lord Phainon, if you require medical attention please contact me ASAP!

Mydei: How’s he going to read this if he’s dying in the street anyway?

Hyacine: Ah.

As expected, his friends were busy taking turns throwing jabs at him for missing their gaming session. Except for Hyacine, who was seemingly more concerned about his ability to ride a bicycle properly. Even Mydei, one of his dearest friends and (un)official partner in life—he was still working on it, alright?—didn’t feel like entertaining him today.

Everyone was focused on returning to their designated schedule, and Phainon was the sole dissenter amidst the choir. He mentally smacked himself for every second he wasted mourning his own misfortune, hastening his reply to not burden his friends.

Team K.A.N.Z

TKQ Thursdays! Don’t forget!

Phainon: I'm fine. I didn't forget anything.

Phainon: Thank you for your concern, Hyacine.

Phainon: As for you, Mydei and Miss Cipher...

Hyacine: Our Deliverer has returned safely from battle! We're saved!

Mydei: So you finally decided to show up.

Cipher: What's taking so long? Time is money, boy. And mine is worth millions!

Phainon: Apologies everyone. But it looks like I won't be able to join you tonight.

Phainon: Or for the foreseeable future.

Mydei: ?

Phainon: So, my account may have been suspended for "suspicious activity."

Mydei: You're kidding.

Hyacine: But why? You were at work all day. Your account should've been inactive.

Phainon: I really don't know. But unfortunately, it looks like our time as a team has reached its end.

Mydei: Don't be dramatic. Just make another account and get back online.

Phainon: Wouldn't that be breaking the rules?

Cipher: Only if you get caught!

Cipher: Use a VPN, kid. You'll be back in no time.

Phainon: I don't know...

Hyacine: It must be very difficult for you.

Hyacine: We spent all that time leveling our characters up and working as a team, just for an unfair suspension to set us back.

Hyacine: I almost want to email the tech support center on your behalf! ٩(๑`^´๑)۶

Despite his friends' best efforts, Phainon did not feel any better about the situation. He already knew that the chances of getting his account back were slim, and even then it felt like an endlessly futile endeavor. Losing one too many *Georios Online* accounts in his youth had already broken his spirits. What was even the point anymore? How could he prevent this endless cycle of suspensions from repeating? He was no computer genius. Some days he was lucky to even get his ancient teleslate model working properly.

While Phainon once dreamed of going into game production as a naive child who knew nothing of the industry, he had since grown and wanted nothing to do with that tedious line of work. Any career that demanded extreme crunching, working until the sun rose and set again and subsiding off of cheap noodles was hardly ideal to him.

Nowadays, Phainon was just a humble post-graduate disappointment still struggling to find employment beyond the realms of “Sales Associate” or “Assistant Kitchen Staff.” His current job working at the Okheman branch of Cery’s Salads wasn’t the worst, even if he was technically struggling to get by. At least he was getting some much-needed vegetables in his diet. The daily commute via bicycle also let him bask in the sunlight instead of rotting away in some corporate dungeon.

Money wasn’t everything, after all. Sure, his debts were something like the glint of a sword lingering overhead, but as long as he avoided frivolous spending, he would make it out mostly unscathed. He was usually more concerned about balancing all his daily activities and ensuring that his companions were kept hale and hearty. That had always been his designated role in the community—Phainon would always be the one looking out for his people. So when it came to himself, he was somewhat at a loss for what to do. Perhaps a web search could help? He reasoned that researching the issue was the best preparation for handling it.

Navigating to his browser, however, Phainon was met with the shame of his latest searches:

> **signs you need a new computer**

> **new computer very cheap**

> **how to make money off appraisals**

> **job application template**

> **how to flirt like a real person**

> **does he actually like me or am i delusional**

> **gladiatr**

He groaned and instantly closed out of the World Wound Web, chucking his teleslate far out of sight. “What is wrong with me?” He wondered aloud.

There was really no other way to go about this. He would just have to accept reality, move on from his losses, and pretend that everything was fine. He’d pick up more shifts and start saving up for a nicer, more functional computer someday. After all, strange errors aside, his computer still worked well enough for the time being. With less free time to amuse himself, Phainon wouldn’t even have to worry about the possibility of losing access to his games again. Eventually, the team would forget about his absence and learn how to become heroes all on their own. They didn’t need him anymore, not really. Sometimes…growing apart was the only way people learned to stand on their own two feet.

Things would change, inevitably—but at the very least, he wouldn’t be burdening them with his own troubles any longer. The sentiment briefly set his heart at ease.

Phainon, lulled by the comfort of his pillows and mountain of baby seal and chimera plush toys, fell asleep that night with a solemn sense of determination brewing in the back of his mind.

In the corner of his room, his abandoned teleslate remained on as unread messages began to rapidly pile up. He had also left the computer monitor on, and it cast a blue haze over the room that rivaled the moonlight. For hours that incriminating verdict remained, surely burning a permanent brand into the screen to always remind Phainon of his misfortune. For much of the night the devices remained on, though his teleslate eventually ran out of battery and it too fell into a deep slumber.

The computer whirred quietly amidst the background noise of Okhema’s nightlife. Not a single new message appeared to prevent it from entering sleep mode, yet still it remained, the sole living thing amongst those lost in slumber. It was a peaceful, if not slightly unusual, scene.

But at the third quint of the Curtain-Fall Hour, the fans suddenly accelerated. Phainon remained undisturbed in his bed, but the sound slowly quickly began to resemble a whirling storm more than a desktop appliance.

The monitor display flickered briefly, and then, at once, the fans ceased and the screen blinked out. Everything in sight was plunged into a deep trench of darkness and the silence grew nauseatingly thick. After a few moments shrouded in this stifling atmosphere, the power was promptly restored and light once again flooded the room. Yet, something was obviously amiss.

The light emitting from the screen was now a blinding golden hue, like a small sun had been hiding inside the circuit boards all along and only just burst out into the world. Though it flickered and dimmed through the long hours of the night, it remained until the dawn broke over the horizon. And then, in a single heartbeat, it faded back into an empty black void.

When Phainon awoke the next morning, neither his phone nor his computer would turn on. Wiping the remnants of sleep from his eyes, he could only sigh over his mediocre breakfast and go about his day as if nothing had happened at all. Though cursed he may be, the constraints of employment were far more demanding. He didn’t have the time to wallow over his own self-inflicted wounds anymore.

“Today will be better. And if not today—tomorrow.”

Just as before, once Phainon turned his back, the computer powered back up and bright flickers of light filled the bedroom. This time, however, a small, invisible figure appeared, outlined only by the golden rays.

It was almost as if something was *alive* inside there.

Chapter 2: Rising Moon

The previous night, as the third quint of the Curtain Fall Hour settled in with the silver moon above, Phainon had fallen fast asleep in his own thorny cradle of repentance. Though his teleslate flashed for hours with new message alerts and his computer monitor suddenly underwent some extreme new developments, he was left to dream in peace for the time being. The situation on the other side of the screen, however, was quite the different story.

To say Mydei was frustrated would be an understatement. He was normally able to restrain his emotions and control unnecessary outbursts, but everything bled into an unfamiliar grey area when it came to Phainon. In this case, the man's seeming inability—*unwillingness*, more likely—to communicate was driving him up the wall. Who just leaves a concerning message like that and then flees the moment someone offers their unconditional support? His avoidant tendencies were nothing new, but at this moment Mydei could only vent his anger in short message fragments.

Team K.A.N.Z

TKQ Thursdays! Don't forget!

Mydei: Phainon

Mydei: Don't you dare just run like that

Mydei: Since when were you this cowardly?

Perhaps it wasn't cowardice at all, but Mydei was quickly losing his patience. Usually this type of bait hooked him in right away. He must be

ignoring them.

Mydei: PHAINON.

Hyacine: I don’t think this is helping

Hyacine: We shouldn’t bother him if he’s feeling uncomfortable

Hyacine: Let’s just be patient and continue on as normal

Cipher: I’m tired of waiting around

Cipher: No more AFK! ヽ•`∩´•ᖇ ዑ

Groaning, Mydei set his teleslate down and returned his attention to the computer. He knew Hyacine was being rational and that his emotions were getting the better of him. But it was just infuriating to not be able to address the glaring issue in front of their faces. What good was turning a blind eye to their teammate’s problems in the long run? Their issues would only begin to stack up until they were entirely insurmountable. Mydei absolutely abhorred indecision and any frailty in one’s will. There was nothing worse than being pushed back into a corner. The only release offered at that point would naturally be at another’s hands, a fate not dictated by himself but by a senseless animal who made decisions based on instinct or tradition. Phainon was never the type to relent to an unjust fate. So why now? What had changed in the few hours since they had last messaged one another?

Mydei tapped away on the screen with his mouse idly. His character, the mighty warlord Nikador who had bathed in the golden blood of ten thousand foes, was resting soundly on a patch of grass with a baby chimera

held tight to his chest. The most ironic part was the fact that it wasn't even his own pet but Phainon's, the little hero Beagle Coconut who never strayed from his owner. Unlike most pets which were tasked with material collection, Beagle Coconut had yet to contribute anything to the team. He was always too busy trailing behind Phainon's character Kephale, shadowing the hero of legend without ever lifting a squishy little paw. But now that said owner was permanently unavailable, the chimera had no choice but to cling to the next best thing.

"If only people were that easy," Mydei mused. Beagle Coconut stretched his pixelated paws up to Nikador's face and purred happily at all the attention he was getting. So spoiled, just like his owner.

In the background he spotted Hyacine and Cipher's characters running around with little multicolored bottles and bags of coins overflowing in their little arms. At least they were still energetic. Mydei already felt as if he had been drained of all life tonight and was ready to start without preparing in advance. It wasn't as if their expedition would be complete without their leader anyway.

The angelic healer of light Aquila spread her wings and began to cast incantations over the skies, creating the few low-resistance damage buffs she had mastered for the whole team. Her skills were still unpredictable given her limited training period, but she was as much an indispensable team member as anyone. She flew back to greet Nikador and picked up her own pet Little Ica while she waited for the final person to join.

After a moderate amount of time doing who knows what, the lightning-fast cat Zagreus popped up from behind a bush in a shower of silver coins. She had actually bothered to equip high-rarity armor this time, though the origin was likely dubious at best, and she even wielded a tiny sword in her hand.

Party Log

Team K.A.N.Z

@KittyPhantom945: I’m the great Deliverer of Dolos! Bow down to your new overlord!

@Twilight252: Amazing, Lady Zagreus! You look ready for battle!

@LordMydei600: Put that butter knife down and go get us some materials

@KittyPhantom945: Butter knife? No shot!

@KittyPhantom945: This is the greatsword NightBreaker

@KittyPhantom945: I am the thief star destined to shine!!! (^_<)〜☆･+゜

@Twilight252: Hehe that’s our hero! (☆◕∀◕)

@LordMydei600: Do you want to do the quest or not?

@KittyPhantom945: Looks like someone’s in a bad mood

@KittyPhantom945: I get your little boyfriend’s a mess but

@KittyPhantom945: That’s his problem, not ours!

@Twilight252: …(•ᴗ•,,)

@Twilight252: What she means to say is that

@Twilight252: Lord Phainon wouldn’t want to see us moping around!

@LordMydei600: She didn’t say that at all.

Once Cipher was done messing around with her reenactment of the Deliverer’s decisive battle against the Mad King, Mydei elected himself as temporary team leader and ushered everyone out away from the city marketplace into the wilderness. While Nikador may have donned the toughest armor in the game alongside a fearsome lance, little Beagle Coconut remained latched onto his shoulder and refused to get off. Naturally, Zagreus spammed the laughing emote a hundred times as he attempted to pry the chimera off, while Aquila hovered beside them, emitting hearts from her eyes. After a fruitless struggle against the pixelated pet, he decided to just give up and pretend Beagle Coconut was a part of his warrior getup all along. The team was missing a core member, after all, so it was only right that he acquired a co-leader. Not that the chimera would be of any use, save for emotional support purposes.

Through the windy wheat fields and winding groves they traveled, exclusively facing low-level enemies they could dispatch without much effort. Working as a trio was somewhat uncomfortable, mostly due to the fact that their coordination was off-balance without their main offensive unit. The usual battlefield dance went as such: Kephale took the lead in offense, Nikador played defense, Aquila worked on casting spells from above and Zagreus did more off-field damage. Now, though, the state of affairs had shifted considerably.

Zagreus could run circles around a dozen enemies without issue, but she was lacking when it came to swordplay. Nikador could easily double as

both an offensive and defensive unit, but attempting to shield both Zagreus and Aquila at the same time he lunged at an enemy was a taxing ordeal. Aquila was also having her fair share of troubles now that she had to balance between restorative spellcasting, combat boosts and offensive maneuvers of her own. Overall, they were barely functional at best. Targeting weak enemies was only a temporary strategy that would never work out in the long-term. Either they had to reconfigure their battle strategies, or they would need to restore everything to its proper working order.

@LordMydei600: This isn’t working

@Twilight252: I was afraid you’d say that

@Twilight252: My spells just aren’t powerful enough yet

@Twilight252: If I had more time, then maybe…

@KittyPhantom945: No point beating yourself up over that

@KittyPhantom945: None of us are working right like this

@LordMydei600: We’ll have to reassign our positions

@LordMydei600: Aquila, go scout above

@LordMydei600: Zagreus, replenish SP

@LordMydei600: I will start cooking

@Twilight252: Yes, Lord Nikador!

@KittyPhantom945: Boring. But I'll do it anyway.

Mydei promptly got to work cooking an array of restorative dishes for the team. He scraped together the remainder of their rations and carefully lit the fire underneath the pot before tossing in an armful of salted dromas steak, scallions and tomatoes. This produced four servings of stew, just enough for the active team members and their currently absent leader. Another armful of vegetables and meat, this time for defense-boosting skewers. Mydei went through his standard menu with intense precision, only breaking his concentration once he reached the dessert course. Pomegranate pie was his personal favorite of all the prepared dishes, not just because it suited his own tastes but also for its HP-replenishing capabilities. He set the ingredients to simmer before reaching out to his teammates again.

@LordMydei600: It's been more than enough time

@LordMydei600: Where are you two?

@KittyPhantom945: Behind you~

Right on cue, Zagreus' cat ears popped up from a conspicuous hole in the ground. Beagle Coconut was startled from his perch on Nikador's shoulder and decided to cling to his head instead, obstructing the character sprite's view of the cooking pot altogether.

Mydei's eyes widened. "Wait, no. Let go, you little—!"

His sprite promptly burned the food. All those perfectly good, ripe pomegranates, now burned to cinders. What an utter waste.

@LordMydei600: Don't do that again

@KittyPhantom945: Not my fault you're such a scaredy chimera

@LordMydei600: You burned the last of our rations

@LordMydei600: We need to go foraging again

@KittyPhantom945: Ugh are you kidding me?

@KittyPhantom945: I'd sooner quit the game than do that again!

@LordMydei600: You were the one who insisted on playing

@KittyPhantom945: But you and pinky still followed along anyway

@KittyPhantom945: Speaking of which

@KittyPhantom945: Pinky? Little angel?

@Twilight252: Sorry. I’m here.

@Twilight252: But there’s something you should see

@Twilight252: It’s really strange. I can’t make sense of it.

@KittyPhantom945: A new enemy we’re too weak to fight? Pass

@Twilight252: No. It doesn’t look like an enemy

@Twilight252: It looks like Kephale

At that, Zagreus and Nikador both took off running towards the faint outline of Aquila’s heavenly figure floating over a tall hill in the distance. The kitty phantom was much faster than the armor-clad warrior and easily left him in the dust, leaving Mydei alone to contemplate just what was happening.

“That’s impossible. There’s no way.”

Turns out there was, in fact, a way. Once Nikador trudged up the hill to join his companions, he too spotted the bizarre scene Aquila had observed.

The hill overlooked an old mire that was long rumored to be haunted. Legend had it that staying overnight in the sunken Styxian ruins granted players a 50-50 chance to either collect the ultra-rare Netherwing Soul Armor, or to die a horrific death and lose all progress on their current quest progress. The team had discussed it at one point, nearly pulled in by the allure of shiny gauntlets that granted high damage mitigation against tough enemy units. Cipher had been most enthusiastic to try her hand at the

gamble, but Phainon's rationality had kept them on course toward their mission.

So why had his character appeared in that same mire now, right after he had essentially lost all of his quest progress?

He leaned down over the cliff's edge to get a closer look, Aquila and Zagreus hovering close behind with an unnerved anticipation. There, beneath the shade of a crumbling temple wall, was indeed Kephale—but he no longer emanated that familiar heroic aura that naturally attracted people to bask in his light. His bright form had been twisted completely by the toxic fumes spewing from the ground. He walked aimlessly in place, sometimes merging with the environment before falling to the ground. And then he would stand again, slowly, as if he were little more than a lifeless puppet without bones in his body to keep him intact. There were bright red patches staining him from head to toe, as if he had been hunting for sport and decided to take a bath in the blood of his fallen prey. Even with his face obscured by distance, the unsettling air surrounding him was more than enough to give Mydei pause.

"What am I even looking at right now?"

He noticed Hyacine starting to type something out in the messages tab, but the team was interrupted by a loud squeal ringing out from the chimera still perched atop Nikador's head. In the blink of an eye, Beagle Coconut had hopped down to the ground and took off in a wild run towards the marshlands, leaving the team behind in a cloud of kicked-up grass. They all blinked at one another with their big, shiny eyes before rushing off again down the hill in pursuit of the fleeing chimera.

Weaving carefully between crumbling columns, the flooded pathways and bones of the deceased, they eventually chanced upon Beagle Coconut, who was now cowering in the remains of an old dolium. Just as Aquila reached for the chimera to share her healing light, a deep shadow was cast over them from behind. And then, the trio finally came face to face with Kephale.

His eyes were reduced to inky black circles, the sort of face worn only by the reanimated corpses stumbling along the Styxian shores. There were similar black and red welts covering his person, an unmistakable mark of Thanatos carved into his skin. Indeed, Kephale looked just like a member of the dead, and perhaps Mydei could have made peace with that assumption under any other circumstances. But the events of the past day were just too bizarre, too outlandish to make sense of.

For starters, Phainon's account had been suspended, effectively purging the system of his data. Even if this was only a temporary state until access to the account was reinstated, it did not change the fact that this avatar being here now was impossible. The only way it could appear in such a possessed state was if the account had been recovered, or it had been corrupted somehow.

While Mydei had resolved to investigate the matter from up close, the two girls were quick to flee to higher ground. Without taking the time to finish preparations for the next phase of the journey, neither stood a chance against formidable foes reborn from the river of souls. Choosing to play it safe rather than risking all their progress so far, Aquila and Zagreus disappeared in an instant, leaving Nikador and Kephale to gaze upon one another wordlessly.

Kephale didn't move much, at least not towards him. He seemed to be imitating the dead on the shores, with slow animations that lacked any spatial awareness. His head would tilt in one direction or another, as if trying to formulate a single thought. Naturally, as a simple character sprite, that was never going to happen. But Mydei still had his reservations about the situation and decided to check in with everyone else just in case.

He picked up his teleslate again and noticed that Hyacine and Cipher had already attempted to establish contact ahead of him. With a newfound sense of urgency, Mydei began typing away at a rapid pace.

TKQ Thursdays! Don’t Forget!

Hyacine: What’s happening?

Hyacine: His character is here, but…

Hyacine: Why does he look like that?

Cipher: This is super freaky, kid

Cipher: You’re not trying to play a prank on us are you?

Cipher: Because I won’t be fooled by something like that!

Mydei: Phainon are you online?

Mydei: ???

Hyacine: He doesn’t seem to be answering

Cipher: Witchcraft! Necromancy!!

Cipher: =͟͟͞͞ヘ(´_`;)ノ

Mydei: Something must be wrong

Mydei: I’ll handle this

Hyacine: Are you sure, Lord Mydei?

Mydei: It’s getting late. You both need to rest.

Mydei: Besides, this fool is my responsibility

Hyacine: If you insist. But don’t push yourself for too long.

Hyacine: I’ll know if you stayed up all night working again!

Cipher: Have fun, little lion!

Cipher: (^-ᴗ-^) Bye~

Mydei returned to observing the twisted character sprite before him. Kephale hardly acknowledged his presence, their only interaction being the overlapping of shadows upon the ground. Still, Nikador stood resolute, unwavering in the face of something that defied all reason. He wouldn’t leave until the truth came out—and Phainon’s account was officially restored for good.

Chapter 3: Sin of Swallowing the Sun

Mydei had always lived under the assumption that his world would become much quieter without Phainon constantly hovering over his shoulder. That wasn't to say his presence was overbearing or unwelcome in any way, quite the opposite in fact. The man was headstrong and knew just how to push his buttons, often stirring up these wild impromptu competitions that he could never resist.

Their latest battle of enduring heatstroke at the sauna was still raging in the back of Mydei's mind. In that particular escapade they had clashed over dinner plans and decided the only fair and logical way to settle it was through practical means. So, they stripped and piled into the small room clad only in towels in an attempt to endure temperatures that would likely injure a lesser man on the spot.

It was a fierce competition, neither side relenting until they were physically dragged out of the baths by the ear for "bodily endangerment." Given that this all occurred at Aglaea's personal residence, perhaps this outcome should have been expected. She often lamented how her two capable students still indulged in reckless acts as if they had yet to mature. But to Mydei, competitions with Phainon were a secondary form of communication in themself, another way of understanding one another. That's how it had always been, from the time of their first meeting until now.

It had already been five years since then. Back then, Mydei was just a modest and somewhat reclusive second-year history student at the University of Okhema. He tended to shirk social interactions under the excuse of being entirely devoted to this academic career and kept to himself. He lived alone off-campus, ate alone and sat alone most days of his

life. It wasn’t a lifestyle he had long adapted to by any means; on the contrary, there was once a time in Mydei’s life when he was constantly surrounded by loyal friends who treated him as something like a younger brother. He knew what it felt like to laugh and share meals with others, to stay up late gazing at the distant stars and whispering his most childish dreams between the lingering hum of a lyre. He had it all, once. But life went on, and soon enough he had outgrown his naivety.

For Mydei, moving to Okhema for school wasn’t the beginning of some romantic journey, but neither was it an explicit sentencing to a life of isolation. He wasn’t so pessimistic to assume that change negated his lifelong bonds or made him anything less than a born-and-bred Kremnoan. The feeling of missing *something* achingly deep inside never faded, but he was nonetheless resolute. Seeking opportunity in foreign lands was simply his chosen path, no matter what contempt he was met with. He had prepared for nearly every scenario imaginable, whether it be all-too-enthusiastic drunkards on the street roping him into some nonsense or hateful individuals cursing his people in the corridors. It’s just, if Mydei was honest, he hadn’t expected the people of Okhema to be so *indifferent.*

They were, for the most part, lively in their own way and embraced the Okheman traditions written into legend as if it were second nature. In his first year of enrollment, not once had he ever witnessed transfer students being harassed or excluded on campus when it came to celebrating the Festival of Gold or the annual Citizen’s Debate Assembly. They’d hang laurels around every passerby’s head and throw apples into the streets to spread the blessings of beauty and romance. Those who hailed from Dawncloud were particularly passionate about spreading Kephale’s love to all inhabitants of Amphoreus.

But were it an Aidonian or Kremnoan who laid worship to their own passages in those same legends, humbly calling out to Thanatos and Nikador for eternal protection and glory even in death? Or perhaps one of Dolos’ cat-eared partygoers who gave a toast to the God of Trickery’s unprecedented heroics? Suddenly, the hearty people of Okhema were not so keen to celebrate anymore. They did not often voice their discomfort,

perhaps out of fear of retaliation more than anything. But their shifty eyes and grimaces spoke loud enough for them.

Sitting alone in the first row by the lecture hall's windows, Mydei could just barely make out his fellow students passing whispers over their textbooks. For an early morning Classics course, everyone sure was lively. Perhaps it had something to do with the fact that the weather was always perfect in Okhema, casting a mural of golden rays of sunlight over the marble city walls. The citizens were usually in better spirits than the transfers, anyway. Or, perhaps it was a result of the ongoing ruckus on the far side of the hall. Professor Anaxagoras—an inquisitive man of the sciences by nature who had, for some unknown reason, submitted to the call of the humanities instead—was scribbling furiously on the blackboard while a group of students giggled amongst themselves. After a month of enrollment in this course, Mydei was no longer fazed by this all-too-common occurrence. He could only sigh under his breath and try to keep up with the almost nonsensical words pouring out of the professor's mouth.

"Keep laughing, you three, and see just how favorable your midterm reports turn out."

An empty threat. The students knew it as well as he did.

The pink-haired girl, Hyacine, spoke up rather cheerily, "Will you be grading your own teaching assistant just as harshly, Professor Anaxa?"

"Don't test me, Hyacinthia. You, Phainon and Castorice are all in the same boat here." The professor then sent a glare up through the rows of students. "Just as you worthless individuals muttering to yourselves are destined for failure. I should save myself the trouble and just send out your final grade reports now."

This time a lower, but no less cheerful, voice retorted, "Is that so? Because I've seen your grading sheet, and it seems to me like we're already meeting your standards, prof."

Said voice belonged to Phainon, golden boy of the literature department who hid a surprisingly sharp tongue behind a blinding grin. The first time

Mydei had overheard him arguing with the professor mid-lesson, he was completely floored. Respect was one of the virtues ingrained in him from birth, and to talk back to a superior in education was unheard of. Now he knew better. This particular group of students were clearly the professor's favorites, and they were merely engaging with him. Mydei scratched out a spelling mistake in his notes and rewrote the offending word. He should have been focusing on his own work instead of others.

Professor Anaxagoras rolled his visible eye. "Those are just preliminary results. Why don't we go over your midterm assignments now to prepare you for eternal damnation now? I'm sure you spineless fools won't even dare to present your topics before me."

A startled hush suddenly washed over the room. Even Phainon looked taken aback, his endlessly blue eyes wide and mouth pinched into a frown. The person behind Mydei hid a cough away into her cardigan, narrowly avoiding the professor's gaze. No one spoke.

"How predictable. None of you have the courage to face me!" Professor Anaxagoras laughed to himself, still wielding his piece of crumbling chalk more like a weapon than a writing utensil. "Fine then. Disperse and talk amongst yourselves as you please. Try to find a topic that won't utterly bore me to death while you're at it, or each and every one of you is going home with a credit deduction."

The professor promptly slammed his chalk down and walked out of the room, ending his lecture approximately forty minutes early. The stunned silence permeated for a while longer, until the students all seemed to collectively sigh and turn to their neighbors for a proper discussion about their paper topics. Mydei, never one to initiate conversation, sat quietly in his seat as he ran through his own proposal for the hundredth time that day. It wasn't that he lacked confidence in the viability of his research, but rather he was more concerned about how to articulate his thoughts in a way that would appeal to his classmates' *delicate* dispositions.

He ruminated for so long, he hardly noticed when a head of shaggy white hair popped up beside his desk. "Hey! Do you want to join us?"

Of course it was Phainon. Again. He was annoyingly skilled at capturing an entire room's worth of attention with little to no effort. Like a hapless puppy, he practically wagged his tail in anticipation of Mydei's response. There was little use in resisting the way those huge eyes seemed to look straight through to his soul.

"Fine." Mydei collected his materials, trying his best to ignore the blooming smile on Phainon's face. It came at no surprise that he was even brighter up close.

The remaining students had assembled into a group of six, excluding the TA Hyacine who was busy reviewing lesson plans in Professor Anaxagoras' absence. Phainon, ever the ringleader, took his seat at the head and offered everyone the option to volunteer as the first presenter. Though it was an open offer, Mydei also felt the man's eyes digging into his side like a blade, almost as if he was challenging Mydei.

Challenging a Kremnoan? He thought to himself. *Alright, as you wish.*

Mydei stood slowly, towering over his seated classmates, and crossed his arms. "I'll go first then."

An all-too knowing smirk broke out on Phainon's lips. "Very well then. Go ahead…?"

"Mydeimos," he supplied. "I'll be conducting research on the ancient history of Kremnos. Specifically, how significant the Kremnoan Detachment was to the survival of both the Kremnoan and Okheman people of the past. There are unsurprisingly few sources on the Detachment's founding, however—"

"Question." A female student's voice interrupted him only twenty seconds into his presentation. Mydei, a bit startled, bit his tongue and looked at the girl expectantly. Though her eyes failed to meet his, her voice never wavered. "What exactly is the, uh, 'Kremnoan Détaché?' This wasn't in our textbooks."

Always the Okhemans with the flowery words and never the same beauty inside.

Suppressing a sigh, Mydei decided to humor the girl. “The Kremnoan Detachment was a group of exiles who sought glory beyond the walls of Castrum Kremnos during the mad king's reign. This faction, led by the Kremnoan prince, would eventually return to defeat the king with Okhema’s aid.”

“I’ve still never heard of them before. Were they really all that important?”

“The surviving Kremnoans protected the holy city in its end times. Okhema would have met its end far sooner without their assistance.” Speaking their language was oftentimes necessary, though nonetheless irritating.

“Really? I can’t remember any of them being mentioned by name though.” The girl twiddled her pen around as if she were actually thinking inside that head of hers. “The demigods of legend were the ones who saved the holy city from ruin. That’s what the textbooks say. So why insert Kremnos where it doesn’t belong? It’s not like any of that matters anyway.”

It’s not like any of that matters anyway?

Mydei could only hold his fists tight until his knuckles paled, averting his gaze completely from the now wide-eyed group of students before him. According to the way he was raised, though a warrior never shied from a challenge, they must also know when to retreat. This was probably the best opportunity.

He moved to sit back down, only for a slightly taller shadow to block his way.

“Of course it matters!”

Naturally, Phainon had decided enough was enough and stepped in to play savior. He shot the girl a disappointed expression, thoroughly outraged at the scene he had just witnessed. “Just because Okheman textbooks may omit the truth doesn’t mean that it didn’t happen! Don’t let your narrow

minded biases affect your performance in school, or you really will end up with a credit detection like Anaxa suggested."

In the tense aftermath of this confrontation, the girl finally let out a haughty *hmph!* and stormed out of the lecture hall in a hurry. Phainon, still standing between Mydei as some sort of protective barrier, sheepishly smiled at him. "Sorry about that! Now, where were we?"

Somewhat rattled—both by the hostile interaction and by the man's complete 180 in attitude—Mydei sped through the remaining minute of his presentation and sat down amidst his other classmates' stiff claps (and Phainon's cheer of approval, which he also tried his best to ignore). The rest of the presentations flew by in a blur. Mydei was too shaken to even realize the other students filing out of the room until he was left alone with Phainon's little group, who gestured to him with reassuring smiles of their own.

"You did well, Mydeimos. I bet Professor Anaxa will give you an excellent mark this time!"

Disliking all the attention on him, Mydei could only keep his eyes trained on his half-legible notes again and wonder just what had gone wrong today. "Thanks."

Hyacine and Castorice complimented him similarly, both expressing their interest in his unique choice of topic, but Phainon's searching stare never once left Mydei's person, even as he began to pack everything away to leave the hall. They walked out shoulder to shoulder, Phainon practically vibrating like some strange, concentrated energy had suddenly welled up within him and was spilling out through every crevice of his body. When the pair finally breached the doors and stepped out into the sunlight, he let out an exaggerated sigh and practically melted into Mydei's side.

"Say, Mydeimos." His words were quieter now but still clearly beaming. "How would you feel about coffee?"

They ended up at a cheap café half a block away, Phainon sipping on a Belobogian flat white while Mydei took to his usual order of pomegranate

juice instead. Their conversations were somewhat short and rough around the edges, but deep down, Mydei could feel some indescribable emotion piling up higher and higher inside by the moment. Of course, Phainon's defense that day did little to change the indifferent Okhemans' perception of foreigners, but Mydei was at least convinced of his character. It was the first time another student had stood up for him, and also the first time anyone on campus had treated him more like a friend than a quiet and aloof classmate in the background.

As the months went on, they would only grow closer, until Mydei had blended seamlessly into Phainon's life as if they had never been separate to begin with. He came to see Phainon not just as the chaos to his calm, but just as often, the quiet moment before the dawn that stripped him of all restraint.

On long nights they'd lay side by side in Phainon's tiny dorm bed, just barely touching, with only the hum of the air conditioner breaking the silence between them. The hours would pass just like that, not with the usual scent of lust, but comfortable companionship. Even as their relationship grew beyond the comfortable realms of friendship and entered somewhat uncharted and undefined territory, Mydei knew he could always rely on Phainon's presence in his life.

So, now in the present moment, why was this profound, stagnant silence hanging between them all of a sudden?

That long night of watching Kephale's sprite stumble around the screen passed quite slowly for Mydei. He didn't really do anything aside from moving around the ruins in a jerking motion like a corpse and turning into a bizarrely pixelated mess occasionally while the environmental graphics glitched around him. He just circled around Nikador endlessly like a blind wolf trying to hunt for scraps. Mydei almost felt bad for him.

Ultimately, he decided to send the *Trash King Quest Online* customer support a very clipped email demanding answers before heading off to bed before dawn. Though he rubbed at his eyes in an attempt to stay awake, at least his email was flawlessly composed as always. Despite being a little old-fashioned when it came to technology, Mydei was still far better off than Phainon was. He even kept a virtual desktop assistant around for task completion efficiency. Bubbles the Chimera was both an adorable and useful companion for late night ventures such as these. He ran spellcheck through Mydei's email before jumping up into the air, hitting the 'send mail' button with his tail.

"Thank you, Bubbles. Keep watching that game for me while I rest."

Being self-employed meant that Mydei's work hours were extremely flexible. He typically rose in the middle of the morning to get his daily workout in and eat a hearty, balanced breakfast (along with a few stacks of protein-infused honeycakes here and there). Then he would head to the Kremnoan Cultural Center Archives and busy himself with whatever organizational tasks he could find until the Parting Hour's first quint, which left a decent amount of time after his shift for personal matters.

On most days, that meant running errands or meeting up with his friends for a nice home cooked meal. And most of the time, it would be Phainon who showed up at his door begging for scraps like a spoiled stray. Mydei, already halfway through dicing up tomatoes for two servings of braised cloudsheep stew, ignored his watery eyes and ordered him around the kitchen like a servant instead. After enjoying a meal with a side of chatter, Phainon would naturally settle on some kind of challenge for the night. Aside from falling into bed together like they were still starved, gaming was also an easy pick.

While Mydei may have complained about having "actual adult responsibilities" to partake in, Phainon somehow always managed to goad him into hours-long tournaments in *Super Hamsterball Racers: Eternal Land.* For all his technological failings, he had gotten quite good at the game after investing a concerning amount of time into studying all the best racers' techniques online.

Mydei himself was more interested in the level designs than anything, finding a certain appreciation for the surprisingly accurate depictions of Kremnoan history in Nikador's Castrum. Phainon's favorite track—Fairy Park, the eight-lap miniature circuit with twinkly background music and an abundance of critters peeking down from the trees—was a headache in itself, however. Though Mydei never once threw the towel in early, he was definitely lacking in that same enthusiasm Phainon held for a game that consisted of circling around the same track over and over again.

It had been over a month since Phainon had last challenged him to any races, but he hadn't realized just how much time had passed until this uneasy moment of silence appeared as a rift between them. Perhaps that should have been the first sign of what trouble was to come. But really—who could have known what inexplicable events were to soon transpire?

When he returned home to his dim and quiet apartment that night, Mydei stood unmoving in his kitchen for a while before fixing himself some leftovers and moving back into his office space. He had left both his computer and TKQ game running all night and day, too invested in this saga of tracking Kephale's movements to even think of abandoning ship. Unfortunately, the character sprite had all but disappeared. Nikador now sat alone in the Styxian bogwater looking more spirit than hero himself. Taking pity on his character, Mydei steered him back up the hill the group had last congregated on in hopes of catching sight of Kephale once he reappeared.

In the meantime, he thought it best to go through his email in hopes of receiving a response from customer support. Surprisingly, they had actually replied to his earlier inquiries within the same day. Bubbles the Chimera, ever the loyal companion, hopped around in a circle as if he was anticipating the thrill of sending hate mail again. Mydei fed him a virtual treat shaped like a heart before going through the email line by line.

> Dear LordMydei600,
>
> In accordance with *Trash King Quest Online's* privacy policy, we are currently unable to disclose personal information regarding another player account at this time.

> Rest assured, your complaint has been investigated promptly. The team had found that user DawnMaker496 has been suspended for suspicious activity as previously affirmed and the account is no longer accessible. No anomalies have been detected as the user previously claimed. Further information is not able to be disclosed at this time. We request that users send photographic and/or video proof of any alleged incidents.
>
> Have any questions? Send us an email at TKQ_support@GoldMail.net
>
> Thank you,
>
> *Trash King Quest Online* Customer Support Team

That was it? *This* was the best customer support could come up with? What a joke!

“Are you seeing this nonsense, Bubbles?” Mydei seethed, already drafting out an even more clipped response to customer support in retaliation. “*Have any questions?* Of course I have questions! And they didn’t answer a single one!”

The most damning line of all being, of course, “No anomalies have been detected as the user previously claimed.” What in Nikador’s good name were they even thinking, sending such nonsense responses out to their customers like this? Not only that, but they had the gall to demand explicit proof of suspicious activity from *him* when it was their systems that had reported it in the first place!

Slamming down on his keyboard, Mydei fulfilled Bubbles the Chimera’s wildest dreams by giving customer support their deserved reckoning. “You want proof? I’ll give you proof.” He promptly attached three different screen recordings that showed Kephale’s bizarre behavior before once again hitting ‘send mail’. Bubbles did a flip out of pure joy.

Finally digging into his now cold leftovers, Mydei could only feel frustrated at himself for his own inefficiency. *All this time, and I still can’t perform at*

my best for your sake. It was a thought born not of self-loathing, but the stark silence slowly creeping in around him. Bubbles the Chimera chirped away onscreen, but Mydei's teleslate had yet to light up with even a single message. Though it had only been one day, he was already anticipating the staggering loss of his foothold that would throw him even further off-balance than before.

Of course, his fears would just have to come true. That night he messaged both the team chat and Phainon again, hoping to receive any word of his activities, but was met with a wall instead. Hyacine and Cipher hardly had any time to play apart from their weekly sessions, so it was up to Mydei to surveil the account each night and play his unending game of tennis with customer support.

Another day passed the same as before; Mydei woke to see Kephale stumbling around again, he went through his morning routine, headed to work, and returned to only the increased whirring of his computer fan and Bubbles the Chimera's yawns. Another round of fighting customer support, eating cold leftovers and sleeping at dawn's rise in anticipation of some change to come. Not once did Phainon pick up his phone. But that was almost a part of the daily agenda as well.

Phainon wasn't one to be easily pinned down. He spent as much time resisting against the imperceptible fears in his heart as he did clinging to his deepest desires. It was a strange dichotomy, a constant push and pull between desperate attraction and self-conscious reservation.

It was really no surprise he made himself scarce in the aftermath of that incident. Phainon was deeply reliant on his own usefulness, so much that he derived his own self-worth from it. Once he had outlived his own usefulness, it became a matter of gradually blotting out all traces of his existence until he could no longer burden others.

Mydei had already witnessed this particular flavor of self-destruction several times before, and said incidents were only ever resolved with proper face to face conflict resolution. With him, even the smallest errors could quickly evolve into pitfalls. No matter how many times he repeated this cycle of burning himself out to light the way for others, Phainon never could come to love himself enough to give in to his desires. He never once privileged his desire for companionship above another's needs.

The origin of this flaw was still unknown to Mydei. Perhaps Phainon had experienced some traumatic event early on in his life. Or perhaps it was just an integral part of his person, a trait lingering in his DNA that formulated the facade of perfection covering up a deeply fragile ego. He rarely expressed his insecurities, even in an intimate setting free from the prying eyes of outsiders. He'd let Mydei rake over his body with a fine comb, knowing well enough that the faint cracks in his visage would never be at risk of peeling into open wounds as long as he bit his tongue into a bloody pulp instead.

For as much as his bright and wide eyes did the speaking for him, words often failed him in the most crucial moments. All that time studying the finer intricacies of rhetoric, just to fall apart under the watchful gaze of his equal. Words were not needed between them, Mydei had always believed in spite of everything. He truly believed that their lives, being as tightly intertwined with gold as they were, could never deviate from the same path. They were an unspoken definitive—two people that could understand one another's hearts between the ringing gaps of silence and lingering sighs.

But now, Mydei wasn't so sure anymore. Though he had seen it as an outsider, he was particularly unnerved as one now on the receiving end of his martyred seclusion. The cadence of their paean had been cut short, the once-anticipated rests turning into a startling vacancy of sound.

After doing some digging and contacting their mutual friend Castorice, he was at least made aware that Phainon had started picking up more shifts at work lately. Now he was sacrificing all his free time, his interpersonal relationships, to help others while tackling the issue of his finances all on his own. Mydei, naturally, was displeased. More so than being cut out of the equation suddenly, it was almost as if Phainon had never once considered

relying on him to begin with. As if their bond was purely one-sided, not at all the illusion of equality it claimed to be, but rather a single-handed struggle Phainon chose to endure alone. But really—what exactly could he do? How do you make someone listen when they willingly turn their back to yours, covering your weak spot but never once daring to look you in the eyes again?

Worst of all was how obviously unnatural this development was for both of them. Having grown so attuned to Phainon’s body and mind, his wants and needs that he would never outright admit to but still held as any human being did, Mydei could sense the same longing within him no matter where he was. Fleeing was a coward’s way out. Neither side was ever tempted into admitting defeat prematurely, no matter the stakes of the competition. So just how had the white space between them grown so cold with distance and indecision? Nothing about this was right. Still, he was determined to make up for his personal failures no matter what. Resilience in the face of adversity was the only way for a true Kremnoan. So, he continued to fill Phainon's inbox without a moment's hesitation.

Almost seven entire days had passed since the incident when Mydei finally got a reply.

Mydei: Phainon
Mydei: It’s been a long time since you answered your phone
Mydei: Hyacine and Castorice are going to worry about you

Phainon: Just them?

Mydei: So that’s what finally drags you out huh
Mydei: Were you ignoring me this whole time?

Phainon: Of course not! My phone was completely dead
Phainon: I was only able to check it just now

Mydei: Whatever
Mydei: But did you get your account back after all?

Phainon: No. I didn’t even bother emailing tech support
Phainon: Why? Did something happen?

Mydei: You could say that
Mydei: Kephale appeared that same night in Styxia
Mydei: He started walking around in circles like he was possessed

Phainon: What???
Phainon: That is NOT supposed to happen

Mydei: You didn’t give anyone else access to your account right?

Phainon: Of course not!

Mydei: Then you were probably hacked. No wonder your account was flagged for suspicious activity.

Phainon: Unbelievable.
Phainon: You know, I didn’t want to say anything at first. But now I have no choice.
Phainon: This isn’t the first time this has happened

Mydei: You’re kidding.

Phainon: I’m being dead serious Mydeimos
Phainon: This has happened for as long as I can remember
Phainon: I’ll get far enough into an online game and then suddenly my account is gone forever with no explanation!

Mydei: ?????
Mydei: You’ve been getting hacked since childhood and you never thought to tell anyone? Are you actually insane?

Phainon: I don’t know! I thought it was my fault somehow!
Phainon: I didn’t know my characters could revive from the dead and walk around like zombies…
Phainon: ヾ(××)ツ

This was one such occasion where Mydei seriously began to question his taste in men. Maybe he really was lacking in common sense. For how brilliant and witty Phainon could be, he sure had his moments. This entire week was also a testament to that.

Unfortunately, Phainon did not bother answering again that night. Mydei had long resolved to leave customer support alone and simply monitor the account on his own for further anomalies while awaiting Hyacine and Cipher's arrival. The team had agreed to suspend the current quest objectives and instead observe Kephale's behavior now that he had fled Styxia for the more mellow wheat fields of their home base.

Upon leading his character back home, he caught a glimpse of Kephale, who was busy running around in circles again like he was attempting to chase his own tail. What a pitiful sight it was—O, how far the great Deliverer had fallen from grace.

Party Log

Team K.A.N.Z

@LordMydei600: He's at it again

@KittyPhantom945: What a pathetic mutt
@KittyPhantom945: Who even has the time to hack that kid
@KittyPhantom945: It's not like he's good at the game😹

@Twilight252: I just don't understand
@Twilight252: The suspension should've erased the account.
@Twilight252: So why is it still able to be hacked?

@LordMydei600: It's more likely to be a virus

@KittyPhantom945: Ha
@KittyPhantom945: Deliverer, didn’t anyone teach you not to click on suspicious links!

@LordMydei600: He lacks common sense. It’s expected at this point.

@Twilight252: Lord Phainon isn’t that careless
@Twilight252: …Right? (^^;)

Truthfully, he wasn’t. Even someone as technologically inept as Phainon knew better than to visit shady websites and download sketchy files. The issue laid in the fact that Mydei doubted a younger, more naive Phainon even knew what an anti-virus software was, much less how to install one on his computer. If a spyware program had been lurking in the background all along, who knew what kind of malicious people could be taking advantage of him all this time? Or, what if an anomaly of a virus had been secretly extrapolating all this time, awaiting the day until it finally broke through each and every firewall in sight?

Mydei shuddered at the thought. If he ever had children of his own, he would most certainly be teaching them proper World Wound Web safety from day one. Titans knew Phainon wouldn’t be the one to do so, anyway.

It was nearing midnight when another prominent anomaly finally made itself known. Hyacine and Cipher had long abandoned him in favor of catching some sleep, leaving Mydei alone to nurse a hot cup of pomegranate tea. He was calmly browsing his email—since he was no longer chained to customer support by pure hatred—when Bubbles the Chimera suddenly jumped up into the air, closed the tab entirely, and then dissolved into a wave of blue pixels.

“What? Bubbles, what happened to you?” Concerned, Mydei hovered over the desktop assistant application and ran a diagnostics test, only to find that it was allegedly still running perfectly well. It clearly *wasn’t,* but the system had deemed it so.

Now suspicious, Mydei pulled up his idle *Trash King Quest* tab and searched the vicinity for Kephale. As if on cue, the character sprite materialized out of thin air right beside Nikador. He was also different, much stranger-looking than he was in the past. The bloody red splotches all over his body had completely blackened, and he now appeared to be wearing some kind of tattered hood instead of his Deliverer’s armor. Where had he even found such an ugly set to wear? Mydei had never seen such a thing anywhere in the game before.

Kephale was glitching badly now, his form completely unstable to the point that Mydei couldn’t even make out his face. Even his name, DawnMaker496, was no longer legible overhead. The mass of black squares simply appeared as “■■■■■”, a complete corruption of everything the hero had once been and stood for. Phainon would surely be appalled by this outcome, wouldn’t he?

Against his better judgment, Mydei decided that now was the best time to act.

Private Message

■■■■■

LordMydei600: You aren’t Phainon
LordMydei600: What do you want with his account?

■■■■■: ■■■■■

LordMydei600: ???

■■■■■: ■■■■■

LordMydei600: Ok
LordMydei600: Clearly you’re hacked or bugged
LordMydei600: I’m reporting this again

■■■■■: ■■■■■

■■■■■: ■N■■o■t■

■■■■■: ■■A■■B■u■g■

LordMydei600: Then who are you?
LordMydei600: Answer me!

■■■■■: ■■■■■

■■■■■: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■

■■■■■: ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■

>
■01000101■■01110010■01110010■■■01101111■01110010
■■■

> ■■E■■R■R■■O■■R■

> ■■EE■R■R■O■E■■E■B■

> ■3■■3■5■■5■0■3■3■■6■■

> ■■■■■■■■

In an instant, Mydei’s entire screen froze and turned black, and he nearly leapt out of his chair in surprise at the horrifyingly warped error sound effect that blasted out from his speakers. Of course, everything was restored

to order in less than a minute. But TKQ had crashed so spectacularly, Mydei was seriously wondering if he had also permanently doomed his own account to suspension for “suspicious activity”. After seven consecutive days logged in, perhaps that was just inevitable.

Deciding to just finish up some busywork in the meantime, Mydei went about closing all his tabs and reopened his email to scroll through all his employees’ latest gripes about the online processing system’s endless failures.

> From *Godshield_Krateros@GoldMail.net,* 20:43, Subject: Local files?
> From *legionattack1232@GoldMail.net,* 21:09, Subject: Local files?? (help!)
> From *strifegodabove@GoldMail.net,* 21:31, Subject: Processing app. Rejected (help!!!)

His employees were certainly just as useless as *some* people when it came to technology. While he mentally prepared himself to answer about ten different people complaining about the same exact issue, Mydei happened to notice a small box appearing in the center of his screen. He briefly wondered if Bubbles the Chimera, desktop assistant extraordinaire, had suddenly made a triumphant return. But what appeared instead had him completely dumbfounded.

“What are you supposed to be?”

A five centimeter tall *creature* had appeared before his eyes in a retina-searing halo of light. It clearly resembled a humanoid and had blond hair and wings like a little pixie, but the soul-deep gashes across its body seemed to bleed pure, molten gold. As it bobbed up and down in the center of the screen, the creature stared blankly ahead without even a glint of light within its eyes. Mydei stared back at it wordlessly.

Then, a wall of indecipherable text once again flooded his screen

> ■■■■■!■■■■■■■■■!■■■■■!■■■■■■■■!
■■■■■!■■■■■■■■■!■■■■■!■■■■■■■■!
■■■■■!■■■■■■■■■!■■■■■!■■■■■■■■!
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■■■■■!■■■■■■■■■!■■■■■!
■■■■■■■■!!!!!!!!!!

What in the world was happening?

Chapter 4: Frozen Heart

The silence stretched out far longer than mere moments or seconds, but Mydei couldn't recall exactly how long he had stared, almost comically slack-jawed and wide-eyed, at the sight before him.

He blinked. He blinked again.

Nope. Not a hallucination.

The creature was still hovering in place as if it had always been there, about a hundred blacked-out tabs slowly flashing in and out of existence behind it. This effect was just as blinding as the creature itself was upon its arrival, causing Mydei to squint like all the times he'd accidentally left his glasses at home during his student days. Everything about this creature—the blonde hair that spiked up like a chimera's horns on top, the shimmery river of gold pooling throughout its body, even the metallic-looking spikes protruding from its skin—could probably rival the eternally sunny skies of Okhema.

The blood swirling inside its chest resembled the ichor of the ancient Amphorean gods, the same ones portrayed in *Trash King Quest* as boss enemies, as well as the inspiration behind everyone's character sprite names. Though, in all his years as a researcher of the old world, Mydei had never come across a local deity even remotely close to resembling this one. Not even the titankin were portrayed with such jarringly human features.

Be it a fairy, an elf, a deity or the sun itself—this *thing*, however human-looking, was closer to the appearance of a puppet than a living thing. The gashes carved deep into its skin seemed to crack and shatter like the casing on a porcelain doll, or as the towering statues recovered from the depths of Aidonia's snowy wastelands so often appeared in the museums.

It may have been beautiful to gaze upon in its own twisted way. But perhaps it was the watchful eyes of the world that had ruined it in the first place.

If anything, this creature resembled the Blemished aeon above more than a revered symbol of the local peoples. But Mydei hardly knew more about the universe to dictate a common Path motif as opposed to the ghastly mythos of the Xianzhou Alliance, so its origins would likely remain unknown without conducting the proper research into this matter.

First things first, though. He tucked the curious, scholarly side of his brain away for the moment and decided to focus on the current situation. Primarily, discovering the reason for the creature's appearance and restoring his computer to normal.

Mydei quickly inputted *Ctrl+Alt+Delete* on his keyboard and gripped his mouse tightly, rolling a finger over the wheel as he attempted to navigate through the sea of scorched popup windows. The pointer seemed to dislike being controlled, twitching as he moved away from the creature's unholy form to force open the task manager. It almost seemed to *resist* his movements, as if the creature was knowingly sucking the mouse pointer into its vortex of swirling data. Yes, it was far too powerful for its own good already. Mydei's concern for the future of his computer was growing by the minute.

A quick look at the new window revealed all the currently operating programs available for his perusal. The desktop assistant application was still running in the background and everything else seemed to be functional. In fact, at first glance, that program was the only thing still running apart from his engaged TKQ and GoldMail tabs.

Adding that to the fact that Bubbles the Chimera just so happened to disappear right as this *thing* appeared…

Were desktop assistants programmed to be this advanced nowadays? Had he trained Bubbles so well that he evolved into a completely original species? Even growing up as one of the few non-*AmphoMon* fans at school, Mydei had seen how ridiculous the evolutions could get. But *Lv. 1 Chimera → Lv. 33550336 Tormented Fairy Man?* They were clearly missing a step or two in the middle there. Something just wasn't adding up here. Even if Bubbles the Chimera had a super secret hidden godly form that no one

knew about, it shouldn’t be unlocked by linking your TKQ account of all things!

Throughout all of Mydei’s meandering, he failed to realize that his mouse was slowly being dragged back towards the creature into its little fortress of glitching popup windows. In an instant, the task manager was forcibly closed and the creature had extended its chubby hands to grasp onto the mouse pointer.

Mydei frowned and attempted to roll away from it. It didn’t move. Again—nothing. The creature clung to it stubbornly with an iron grip.

“Let go. I have things to do.”

Of course, the creature didn’t budge. And why should it? He was talking to a computer. Not just that, but a set of *pixels* onscreen. It was about time he regained his senses.

A small, strange creature had appeared on Mydei’s monitor after he messaged the unstable game account online. This creature might not have resembled the white-haired hero Kephale in the slightest, but these unusual circumstances just had to be related. Something was clearly malfunctioning behind the scenes, and Mydei had every intention of plucking out the root of the problem.

He powered off his mouse and the triangular icon instantly disappeared from the screen. The creature, now holding onto absolutely nothing, seemed to startle. Its shimmering wings fluttered slightly, creating faint ripples of red in its wake. Though its eyes never once wavered with emotion, it almost looked like it was glitching, unsure of how to proceed without the safety net it had latched onto. Something pulsed uncomfortably in Mydei’s abdomen. He grit his teeth together and turned the mouse back on, hovering back over the tab with his in-game messages before the creature could react.

Private Message

■■■■■

@LordMydei: Are you the one doing this?

■■■■■: ■■■■■

■■■■■: ■■H■■ol■■d■■■

■■■■■: ■N■o■■■T■a■■ke■■

@LordMydei: It’s a yes or no question.

@LordMydei: Answer me.

■■■■■: ■■■Y■e■s■■

Mydei looked over at the creature again. Somehow its form had grown more unstable in the past minute, so bad it was visibly glitching the space around it. Its wings flapped frantically to keep it hovering in place. Still, the look in its eyes was unchanged. The creature’s blank stare was so intense it almost seemed to be looking straight through the monitor back into Mydei’s own eyes. Unnerved, he decided to completely shut down his computer for a soft restart. The creature’s unwavering gaze prickled at his skin as he pressed down on the power button. And though its face had yet to move in any direction at all, somehow it managed to wear an expression darker than the evernight itself.

Five seconds…ten seconds…an entire twenty seconds passed. Mydei's screen was flooded with sweltering patches of red and the fan started spinning rapidly. The monitor itself also increased in temperature, leaving a scorching haze in the air. Beside the creature, the idle tabs had darkened considerably, creating a mirage of violent bloodshed across the scenic overview of the Kremnoan ruins on his desktop.

Sweat gathered on Mydei's brow and still the creature stared at him. Twenty-five, thirty, thirty-five seconds. *What was taking so long?* The fan spun around and around, faster and faster, and a new prompt appeared in the void:

> **Warning! CPU Overheating Alert!**

Was the creature deliberately trying to stop the shutdown? Could it even do that in the first place? Just how strong was this thing anyway?

After an entire minute of sweat-inducing agony, the prompt finally appeared amidst a sea of glitching red static. Mydei slammed the POWER DOWN button and the screen cut to black. Gone were the creature, the overheating and the illusory battlefield that had clouded his senses—almost as if they had never existed in the first place.

Finally exhaling, Mydei slumped down on his desk just low enough that he could barely make out his surroundings. Up on the shelf between some old poetry volumes were several framed photographs taken at a festival in the city years ago. The sun shone in a corona around the lens, painting all his friends in a dazzling light. Even from the dimmest corner of his office, Mydei easily spotted all the shots with Phainon in them. With a wide grin and an arm looped securely around Mydei's neck, he was always too bright to ignore.

Beside the photographs were a few souvenirs and Fig Stew the Chimera plushes, nestled right up against his pitch-black computer monitor. Mydei wasn't usually the collector type, but once his friends discovered one of his passions, they latched onto it as the go-to for every gift-giving occasion.

Castorice in particular was always finding new crochet patterns to make little outfits for everyone's chimera toys. Currently, Fig Stew was wrapped up in a bright blue sweater decorated with little clouds, a shared set with the Beagle Coconut plush back over in Phainon's apartment. Even their chimeras were a perfectly matched pair. It was something like fate.

No use thinking about that now. Mydei was too curious about the current issue with his computer to be bitter anyway.

Nothing was there on the screen, save for the faint halo burned into it, though even that was little more than a hazy afterimage now. Just a small proof that it hadn't been some exhaustion-induced fever dream.

Thinking back to the beginning, every step in this convoluted series of inexplicable events was difficult to accept as being *real.* On their own, each anomaly made absolutely no sense at all.

A suspended gaming account. The resurrected character sprite and cryptic private messages to accompany it. Bubbles the Chimera disappearing, only to be replaced by a fairy with golden eyes. And said fairy tried to forcefully keep his PC running by locking the mouse pointer in place and spurring up a torrent of glitches all over the screen.

But now, everything that had happened these past several days was neatly linked before him in a linear timeline of events. And the very first link in the chain, the origin of this entire mess, was none other than…

"Did you seriously pass your little computer virus onto me, Phainon?" Mydei groaned into his sweater sleeve. No one was around to hear his complaints, but he felt like voicing his frustrations was the only way of coping with this so-called "revelation". After all, he was the one who pushed Phainon to order a new computer in the first place after he reported issues during previous gaming sessions.

It got to the point that Mydei even offered to order one himself. But Phainon, being Phainon, was not one to accept charity without giving something of equal value in return. Like an overeager dog, he had promptly dropped 50,000 balance coins into Mydei's in-game wallet and mailed him

an ultra-rare SSS-Rank pair of Kremnoan Steel gauntlets as a “free inclusion”. Naturally, the whole ordeal quickly turned into a competition of who could procure the better in-game gift package, and both he and Phainon had forgotten the original issue altogether in favor of draining their virtual banking accounts.

Now, Mydei could only regret not having put his foot down back then and there to prevent any future computer troubles on Phainon’s end. Not to mention the fact that half of the current situation was his own fault to begin with; it was Mydei who decided to message a visibly glitching account that even the owner no longer wanted to deal with. For a man who prided himself on restraint, he always seemed to betray his own sensibility when it came to Phainon. Just why was indulging in foolishness so irresistible when it came to him? Why couldn’t he stay levelheaded at such critical moments? Was a pair of wide, pleading blue eyes—eyes so full of light they too were almost blinding—all it took to ruin him entirely?

In the lingering silence, he could almost hear his partner's lilting voice retorting, *Viruses are known to spread, Mydeimos, especially to those in* very *close proximity.*

What an absolute mess the two of them were together.

In between the unending time spent staring at his monitor with a look of pure exasperation and pacing his room in search of anything to keep his mind off of Phainon’s glaring absence from his life, Mydei channeled his frustrations into his passion for research.

Though this was hardly comparable to the enjoyable work he conducted at the archives every day, and he only found himself growing more frustrated at the holes surrounding each aspect of this anomaly. Even his searches grew unrefined with time, as if he himself had yet to dig even an inch

beneath the surface and was just grasping at the very topmost layer of the soil for anything:

> **how to make employees more self sufficient**

> **add nutrients for better salads**

> **best ways to show partner you care**

> **restore tkq suspended account**

> **tkq hacked bugged account help**

> **computer virus bypass antivirus program**

> **fairy elf computer virus**

> **signs you need a new computer**

“This is unbearable,” he groaned. So much for being the most competent staff member at the cultural center who was the sole person in charge of the electronic archives system. His brain was about as fried as his CPU.

He was tired, hungry, and running out of patience. Soon enough it would be the Entry Hour again, and he’d have officially stayed up *way* too long. Mydei was always lecturing his friends about maintaining a balanced lifestyle that consisted of a healthy diet, daily exercise, and no fewer than eight hours of sleep every night. Now it was his time to play hypocrite, he supposed. Just another thing Phainon had passed onto him this month.

He clearly needed to rest as soon as humanly possible. Flicking his attention back over to the screen, the creature was holding his mouse pointer hostage again. Nothing the old “turn it off and back on again” trick couldn’t solve though. It seemed just as agitated as before, but at least it didn’t throw another computer-melting tantrum. Perhaps it had learned its lesson after the first time being forcibly shut down.

Mydei moved the mouse over to the task bar to put everything in sleep mode. But as it turned out, in his absence, another grim surprise had been laid out for him like a trophy.

What was once the desktop virtual assistant program had transformed into something more sinister. The icon, which was *supposed* to be a simple PNG of Bubbles the Chimera, had also changed. No longer was Bubbles exiled to the corner like a prisoner, unable to move or say anything under the creature's watchful gaze. Now he was just slumped over with a black greatsword lodged into his side. There wasn't blood or anything too graphic, but this too unnerved Mydei beyond words.

"*Titans,* you're sick," Mydei mumbled to himself. He quickly unpinned the application so he wouldn't have to look at gore of his comfort chimera anymore. "What did Bubbles ever do to you? Don't tell me you lost at *Seal Slammers* one too many times and took it *way* too personally."

The creature continued to watch him without a hint of remorse. With its sharp tufts of hair and narrowed eyes, it somewhat resembled a cat at certain angles. It even brought Mydei an offering to earn his approval. Again, *grim,* but it was the thought that counted.

Or maybe he was just losing all rationale as the night stretched itself thin.

Glancing back towards the exit from this personal hell, he spotted the application returning from its previous dismissal. Just how stubborn was this thing? At least it had the decency to revert the icon back to a black square. Now, without the gruesome trophy in front of him, Mydei noticed the conspicuous file name. No longer was it titled *Bubbles.exe* but rather…

"*δ_me13?* What even is that?"

He clicked on the icon multiple times, hoping to reload the application as he had earlier, but the program file refused to load. Another error message reading "■■H■i■■!" then appeared.

Mydei, at that moment, decided he'd officially had enough for one night.

After a full eight hours of sleep, an early afternoon exercise session, brunch, and a mere three hours spent at the office (which earned him more than a few frustrated huffs from Krateros, who still couldn’t figure out how to open files sourced from a cloud), Mydei crawled back to his ever-silent apartment with a bag of takeout from Kyros’s Grille in hand and obsessively scanned his computer for any new developments.

His observations were as follows:

1. The creature was still there
2. He had forgotten to turn the mouse off and the creature was holding it again
3. Bubbles the Chimera was still M.I.A
4. TKQ was running at 8 fps and only the messages feature worked
5. His computer was practically boiling after running for so long

Now aware that the World Wound Web was basically useless, Mydei decided to return to his team for assistance. Even if Hyacine was busy running around the hospital as usual, there was a chance Cipher would be lurking online.

Team K.A.N.Z

TKQ Thursdays…?

Mydei: Look at this

Mydei: strangevirus.mp4

Mydei: Thoughts?

Hyacine: What exactly is this?

Mydei: The consequences of chatting with the possessed Kephale

Mydei: Definitely wouldn’t recommend doing that

Mydei: Do you have any ideas, Hyacine?

Hyacine: Sorry, Lord Mydei (• ∩ • ｡)

Hyacine: Intellitrons are people too, but…

Hyacine: I only know how to take care of human patients!

Mydei: It’s alright. Thanks for always doing your best.

Cipher: Well it’s definitely a virus!

Cipher: Doesn’t look like a Janus Steed or True Sting though

Cipher: So it must have infected TKQ directly and spread

Mydei: How can you be sure?

Cipher: Because I’m not seeing any new corrupted files

Cipher: That’s how they usually get you ค/ᕑ.‿.ᐟ\ค

Mydei: I see.

Cipher: I thought you’d know better than the Deliverer though!

Cipher: ALWAYS keep an antivirus on your PC, little lion!

Mydei: I already have one

Mydei: It just got bypassed. Somehow.

Cipher: Which means your antivirus got infected too

Cipher: ξ(ᵕ̈> ᗜ <ᵕ̈)

Mydei: Cipher, please. It’s not that funny.

Cipher’s intel had essentially confirmed what he had already known. The creature was undoubtedly a virus that used Kephale as a vessel to enter his computer.

“Which means you hid yourself in TKQ on Phainon's computer. He only had to play the game as usual to let you inside.” Mydei ran a hand through his choppy bangs and sighed. Even his voice had turned ragged and

scratchy after a poor night's sleep. This was exactly why maintaining a strict routine was so crucial. Why couldn't he just follow his own advice for once? "And then I went investigating the anomaly, falling into the same trap as he did in the end."

Thinking about Phainon had previously made him itch, but now that sensation had transformed into an actively nagging need to go seek his other half out and get some solid answers for once.

Most of all, Mydei needed to *see* him. To confirm that Phainon was still in one piece, was still breathing and eating and taking decent care of himself through these times of unease.

Mydei: I know you're not going to bother reading this

Mydei: So I'm just going to come over

Mydei: You better be ready to talk when I get there

He also decided to send a message to Castorice. If not to determine Phainon's whereabouts, then at least to update her on the situation. She might not have been part of their little gaming team, taking more interest in creative hobbies, but she was still a dear friend to everyone.

Mydei: I'm guessing you haven't heard from Phainon either?

Castorice: Sorry. I'm not really of any use.

Castorice: I do think of him as my best friend

Castorice: So it's quite disheartening for me as well

Mydei: I know, Castorice.

Castorice: And I did talk with Cyrene this morning

Castorice: She hasn't heard from him either

Mydei: He's even ignoring her? That's a new low

Castorice: I'm sure in Phainon's mind he must have a good reason for all of this

Castorice: I just wish it didn't have to manifest in such an upsetting way…

Mydei: I'm tired of waiting

Castorice: I know you're frustrated, Mydei

Castorice: We all are. And you're so close, it must be difficult.

Castorice: But what are you planning to do?

Mydei: What I should've done from the beginning

Mydei: Confront him face to face, obviously.

Castorice: …

Castorice: And you’re sure this will work?

Mydei: He can run all he wants

Mydei: But at the end of the day, he’ll still come home

Mydei: I’m sure of it

Castorice: Hm.

Castorice: Be safe, then. I’m wishing you luck.

Castorice: (´ᵕ`)♡

It was still the first quint of the Parting Hour, and the sun had yet to set outside his window. *Now or never,* Mydei thought as he strapped his boot buckles back into place. He shrugged on his wool overcoat, deciding to forgo his keys in favor of walking. Phainon lived just twenty minutes away on Marmoreal Main Avenue, his apartment block built atop the marketplace from days past.

The oldest slates all heralded it as the life force of the eternal holy city, a true cultural center kept alive not by paltry documents plundered from the ashes of a decayed world, but one with blood coursing hot through its core. No one in this era of Amphoreus had ever known a world like that. They all simply existed in the shadow of an impossibly heavy past—the fate of one born beneath a blazing sun who can never hope to grasp its warmth.

Mydei let his feet carry him on the familiar route through the pearly heights of the mountain city as if it were home. And perhaps it was, after six years of living here among its people; though it would be his second, if he was counting his childhood home in Kremnos. His mother would have his head if he ever suggested otherwise.

The winding, picturesque streets were a far cry from the wasteland that the modernized Kremnos was built upon. Okhema was the last surviving city-state of the ancient world, of course, so even evening walks could feel like touring a historical site. Children tossed toy balls down the hills and danced around in circles holding hands, and flowers bloomed between the small cracks in the pathways, but the holy city would always remain a landmark in the eyes of the greater universe. And nothing captured that angle quite like the gargantuan pillars of Theosphere Lake that loomed at the city's summit.

The waters had once dried up completely, but with the Council of Elders' proposal to reinvigorate Okhema as the true heart of Amphoreus, a complete restoration project was enacted over the course of a thousand years. The pillars bearing the marks of the ancient gods were the last surviving emblem of Amphoreus' cultural traditions, and it would be each succeeding generation's duty to ensure they never crumbled.

Mydei, while not the type to entertain such religious zeal, sympathized with their efforts. Forget the gods of old altogether, this was their entire *world's* history. Preserving it for the future was always his best interest as a historian who understood the present through the lens of the past.

He had held impossibly old photographic records in his own two hands, felt their yellowing sheen with his own skin, let himself be immersed in moments so far removed from his reality. Those accounts from millennia ago were proof enough that the ancient gods once inhabited Amphoreus just as humankind did. The stone statue of the Worldbearer had long crumbled to ash, but remnants of their glory were commemorated with a much more humble monument at the holy grounds of Dawncloud.

Mydei had seen it for himself on multiple occasions, and it did stir something within him.

Even without the grandeur of the past, Kephale was still an impressive sight to behold. They were the only titan whose complete form was found in the ruins of the old world; though the divine tree of Cerces still stood in the Grove of Epiphany, its hollowed and shriveled form had been slowly rotting away since time immemorial.

The ancient academy was open to the public for tours, but complete restoration of the area was deemed impossible without the influence of memoria. Those priests who still worshiped Oronyx would pray at their god's altar for blessings that would never arrive, just as the cold gaze of the aeons always passed by their little world with indifference. In the end, the Grove of Epiphany was never rebuilt. Only a handful of texts that hadn't sunk into the mire of boiling gold were salvaged from that beautiful library.

Though the University of Okhema had been deemed the successor to the Grove's academy, the bustling city streets could hardly compare to the natural serenity of its predecessor. Dew rarely sat untouched on grass that always bathed in sunlight. The noise pollution generated from traffic in the lower city rang constantly in his ears. SoulGlad advertisements were found on every billboard of every street corner, and ships from above would often fly in and out of sight, traveling far beyond the small world that he called home.

Sometimes Mydei also wondered what kept everyone here. Cipher and Professor Anaxagoras could find themselves in any line of work beyond the starry skies, and Aglaea would certainly be a renowned seamstress for all the universe's most prolific celebrities. Hyacine could study medicine on another planet, and perhaps Castorice would take her sister along to tour the grandest gardens out there.

Phainon and Cyrene would suit the role of galactic travelers well. The love they both held for their hometown was unparalleled, but the world beyond the skies had utterly captivated them as children. That was the reason they relocated to Okhema in their adolescence, after all. So it was a wonder they hadn't jetted off to some alien port town as soon as they reached adulthood. But the lively Cyrene just skipped around the world in circles, and Phainon remained comfortably in place. He hadn't even taken the opportunity to

visit the Penaconian branch of Cery's Salads for its grand opening celebration.

(Mydei would never forget how Phainon's boss chewed him out over the phone the next day as if he had personally offended her entire bloodline. Apparently her lover had prepared a generous gift basket for the "feast," and his quiet refusal was akin to declaring war on the CEO herself. He'd ended up holding onto Mydei quietly that entire night, his face gaunt and hands trembling. Who knew such a small foe could inspire such fear?)

No, it hardly made any sense at all. None of them were chained by their past, nor was there any imminent danger lurking in the shadows. Amphoreus was always peaceful, as far as he knew. It was rare to find a world so unburdened by war and violence. By all means, all of his friends should have set out to see the stars by now. Mydei would always be here, waiting for the day they eventually returned.

And yet, here they all remained. It was as if they had no ambitions at all besides living a peaceful life together in Amphoreus' most beautiful city. Mydei could understand that feeling well enough. Even now, he was running to catch up with his ever-so-stubborn "equal," the one who had never outpaced him before.

Too many anomalies were cropping up everywhere in his life. He had to regain control before it all began to spiral out of his grasp for good.

Arriving at Phainon's place, Mydei raised a hefty fist and knocked three times on the front door. He waited for only a few tense moments before repeatedly pounding on the door with the knocker. Nothing.

That constant silence was always getting to him.

He dropped his hand to rummage around in his pocket for the keys to the apartment. Phainon had given him the spare the very day he moved in, mumbling something about *unlimited free homemade meals* against his lips as he crowded Mydei against his completely barren walls. The searing heat of those fragile moments lingered in his mind every time he brushed his fingers over the hard metal ridges, feeling the small letter “P” engraved on the head. Or, in this case, the *lack* of said feeling.

At that moment, Mydei distinctly remembered his previous decision to leave his keys behind; *all* of his keys, the spare to Phainon’s apartment included. Huh.

Humorlessly, Mydei laughed and fell backwards to lean against the door. “So that’s how it is. Everything between us is contagious. Even your idiocy is infecting me now.”

Or, as Castorice would reinterpret through her usual poetics: *Souls entwined with golden threads shall never be parted.* Well, she was always more inclined to follow in Aglaea’s footsteps in pursuit of life’s greatest beauty. But Mydei saw no point in denying what was obvious to the rest of the world.

Was his foolishness just as apparent now? Maybe. He had spent the better half of a month trying to track down the origin of the virus infecting his boyfriend’s computer without ever actually consulting a professional (no, strangers on the local forums did not count, they were practically useless anyway). He got pulled so deep into this venture that he ended up infecting his own computer with said virus, and now it was wreaking no small amount of havoc on his CPU.

He had run out to meet Phainon when he wasn’t even home, forgot his keys, even forgot to double check the weather forecast for tonight because it was always supposed to be sunshine and rainbows in Okhema, *how could he have anticipated literally anything else?*

Tiny, frigid drops fell flat on Mydei’s head from the clouds high up above, further muddying his mind. Nothing made sense anymore. But maybe it already hadn’t for a long, long time. Maybe, these anomalies were there

from the very beginning. He was just lost in a daze after being exposed to the unfamiliar, blinding rays of hope.

The early days of their relationship were somewhat rocky in the same way that most university friendships were. Granted, part of that was a result of Phainon's brainless attempts at chatting him up, and Mydei was already put off by the sheer amount of times the man could reference his “perfectly sculpted body” in a single conversation. So maybe “friendship” wasn't exactly the right word to use here. But the Mydei of that time was too hesitant to try putting any labels on the new and fresh thing between them, so he digressed.

Their usual post-lecture café dates continued without a hitch. Phainon was especially eager to talk about their ongoing research projects, always probing Mydei for more information about his latest finds in the university archives. He’d sip obnoxiously on his latte, flash Mydei an even more obnoxious grin and lean his cheek into his palm as if lukewarm conversations about ancient Kremnoan battle formations made him swoon. And when Mydei politely motioned for him to discuss his own paper, he merely laughed and shook his head.

“No, please. My project really isn’t that interesting. I want to hear more about you!”

The remainder of the fall semester went on much the same way. After a solid four months of mentally kicking himself over all the painfully awkward and one-sided conversations he endured, Mydei didn’t place much faith in their little tradition surviving winter break.

On the thirty-second day of the Month of Fortune, just after the conclusion of the final day of classes, Phainon was waiting for him outside the lecture hall as usual. Mydei exhaled slowly, hiked his satchel up on his shoulder, and approached. He was instantly struck with one of Phainon’s signature blinding grins. It was almost too bright to look upon directly.

“Mydei, hey! Ready to go? I know the semester’s already over, but I’m sure you have tons of interesting projects lined up for the spring—”

“Actually.” Mydei bluntly interrupted his tirade. It was just like ripping off a bandage, right? The quicker he got this painful interaction over with, the better. “It’s probably better if we just went home.”

Phainon blinked at him slowly. Once, twice, three times. Mydei nearly began to sweat under the attentive gaze of his huge, sky blue eyes.

And then, he blushed from head to toe brighter than any overpriced bottle of pomegranate juice sold on campus.

He stuttered out, “*O-oh.*…” and instantly held out his hand to Mydei. He stared at it, then at Phainon’s expectant expression, and then back at the hand. What was he…?

“Are you not the hand-holding type? Sorry. I’m ready though, so lead the way!”

Just what kind of hole had Mydei managed to dig himself into now? Surely, Phainon didn’t think he was inviting him over to his place, did he?

Who was he kidding, of course Phainon thought exactly that.

After another lengthy, painful moment of silence, Mydei gave a tired sigh and *yanked* Phainon forward by the hand. Phainon yelped, but decidedly bit his tongue as Mydei proceeded to thread their fingers together. He really wasn’t the hand-holding type, but this whole day was already enough of a disaster. What was one more inconvenience added to his infinitely-expanding list?

If their conversations never went anywhere, they were better off not talking all night.

On the first day of the Month of Balance, the very instant Mydei entered his 8 AM art history class, he spotted Phainon perched on a wooden stool at the

front of the room. Mydei stopped in the doorway, swallowed, and walked inside. He was instantly struck with an unusually affectionate expression from Phainon. His smile was still bright enough to sear a permanent image in his mind, but those ruddy cheeks and drooping eyes were definitely new.

“Mydei,” he called out, almost too soft. “I didn’t know you were in this class. Did Tribbie recruit you on the street?”

He’d moved his bag from the stool beside him to the floor, gesturing for Mydei to take a seat. As he entered the classroom fully, he saw only one other student—a purple-haired girl who was seated to Phainon’s left. She watched him carefully from behind a large drawing pad, as if she were observing him for a composition of some sorts. Mydei sat down stiffly, trying his utmost to ignore the blatant stares he was receiving. What a pain this was already turning out to be.

Never one to mince his words, Mydei dryly replied, “I’m majoring in history. It isn’t unusual for me to enroll in Professor Goldweaver’s class.”

Phainon and the other student immediately turned to look at one another, poorly hiding giggles behind their hands. Mydei crossed his arms and tried not to feel too put off. He could very well move his stool away if things got too uncomfortable.

For all his previous blunders, Phainon seemed to read his body language perfectly well now that they were in another student’s company. “Sorry, sorry. It’s just—I’ve never heard anyone refer to Aglaea so formally like that!”

“We found it endearing,” the girl added with a shy smile. “You’re Mydei, right? I’m Castorice, a friend of Phainon’s. We’ve both been taking Aglaea’s art classes since our first year at the university. We weren’t expecting anyone else to enroll in this section.”

“Nice to meet you, Castorice. I honestly just needed an art credit and this was the only option available to me. The time probably threw most people off.”

Phainon suddenly interjected, “Aglaea’s classes are something of a niche. Only the most cultured of students find their way into her lectures!”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Then why are you here?”

“Wh—Mydei! That stung!”

Castorice giggled to herself again, and Mydei secretly concealed a smile of his own. This was the most comfortable conversation he’d had with Phainon so far. Were they just missing a third party all this time, a quiet and sensitive person like Castorice to keep them both grounded firmly in reality? Phainon, despite the awed look emanating from his eyes, was finally responding to him instead of sitting passively while Mydei talked. Maybe Castorice’s presence encouraged him to feel more comfortable and break out of his shell? Though, thinking back, Mydei had never taken him for an introvert at all…

Mydei turned his attention back to Castorice, opening his mouth to ask about their friendship history, but he was interrupted by a pointed clearing of the throat right beside his ear. Mydei shot Phainon a dirty look, and though he seemed to sulk like a neglected dog for a moment, he immediately straightened upon hearing the classroom door opening and several pairs of feet entering.

“Snowy! Little Cas! We’re back!” A child’s cheery voice broke through the otherwise quiet room. Said voice belonged to a little redheaded girl wearing a rocket-shaped backpack who was holding about ten too many stacks of documents in her hands. She was accompanied by an elegant-looking woman that could only be Aglaea.

Phainon quickly snapped back to his usual self. “You already have the course syllabus ready? You’ve become such a diligent assistant, Tribbie.”

“Aw, thanks Snowy! But there’s no need for this show of flattery. I think our new friend here already likes you, even if you are a little silly sometimes.”

The girl, Tribbie—who was apparently their teaching assistant despite being no older than nine years old—also cast a not-so-subtle glance over at Mydei and giggled.

They're all exactly the same, Mydei bemoaned. *I might be at a disadvantage here.*

Despite his initial worries, the rest of the spring semester went smoothly enough. The quartet of his art history course quickly integrated themselves into Mydei's everyday life as if they had always been there. From slow afternoons spent lazing around Castorice's dorm room, evenings cramming in the library, their class trips to Okhema's local art museums and Tribbie's numerous (failed) attempts to play driving instructor for Phainon, every interaction was like reclaiming something he had lost ages ago.

Mydei and Phainon shared a bed more times than they could count, and only about fifty percent of that time was spent sleeping. When they weren't busy falling into one another, they'd play games on Mydei's old home gaming console until the weight of their latest assignments caused their bruised eyelids to droop shut for the night. Their habits soon became routine, became a formal schedule that even invaded Mydei's calendar. He began to actively plan his life around Phainon and his newfound friends at school, something he had never once considered as a possibility.

He was happy back then. A little naive, yet so happy.

But then summer came along, and with it, an unbearable heat that left his skin crawling. Phainon, who was always smiling just in his periphery, had begun to drift further out of sight until his gleaming visage had all but disappeared.

Seven days. That's how long it had been since they had talked.

And there Phainon was, standing under the awning outside his building as the sun beat down on the city. The faint lines on his face were pulled taut, painting his handsome features in a more severe light than usual. He looked

almost unapproachable from a distance, though he was wearing his favorite mustard-colored flannel and the leather satchel Aglaea sent over for his birthday last month. She hadn't let him wear such a "loud" shirt back then, insisting he take home one of her personal creations in exchange for a short modeling session. As usual, Phainon was only amenable to the gifts if he was of equal use to the giver. Mydei had just presented him with a gift card to their favorite café and demanded they go out for coffee after class again. And Phainon was more than happy to oblige.

They'd been doing better since the semester's start, no longer constrained by awkward self-consciousness as they steadily grew closer and closer. Mydei was even comfortable enough to let this man sleep in his bed every night without question. So what was with this tense atmosphere between them all of a sudden? Had he come on too strong too quickly and scared Phainon off? No, impossible. Phainon was the very definition of "coming on too strong." Mydei hadn't forgotten all the terrible flirtations he'd been forced to endure throughout the fall semester.

Phainon didn't seem to notice him approaching until Mydei swung an arm around his neck and mimicked strangling him. He looked panicked for all of a second before relaxing into Mydei's hold and sighing. "Oh, hey Mydei. I don't know how I didn't see you coming, what with that terribly conspicuous body of yours always drawing a crowd across campus!"

Huh. Maybe things weren't that off between them after all.

Mydei tightened his grasp, causing Phainon to cough and start squirming free for air. He sneered, "Still talking nonsense at a time like this? You have some nerve after ignoring me all week."

"Ack! I…I was busy, okay? Super busy! With my internship straight from the Nether Realm!" Phainon choked out. He managed to break free and gasped for breath, turning to Mydei with a glare as he rubbed at the skin beneath his leather collar. "Since when were you such a sadist, Mydei?"

Mydei promptly ignored him and dragged him off in the direction of the Golden Scapegoat Café.

“Hurry up. I want pomegranate juice and a pastry.”

Phainon only shot him an exasperated look before straightening himself out and following in Mydei’s stead. And that was the extent of their confrontation back then. Mydei never pushed too hard, always afraid to overstep his boundaries and cause Phaino to further retreat into himself. All he could do was shove Phainon lightly in the right direction and ensure he never strayed from the group for too long. And most times, it worked.

Heavy undereye bags during exam season? An extra large coffee and a warm bed to nap in after class it was. Arguments with groupmates over a presentation? Nothing a few laps around Styxian Shoals and Rainbow Bridge couldn’t solve. Anything less than an “A” on his final exams? Going on a stroll through the meadows located on the outskirts of town was great for clearing the mind.

At the time, Mydei had everything perfectly under control. Or, so he had thought.

But now? Now, he most definitely had his regrets.

Even with an overcoat, Mydei wasn’t safe from the sudden rainstorm that came crashing down from the skies above Okhema. As the hours drew on and his eyes fought to stay awake, he hardly even felt the raindrops soaking his entire body anymore. All he could do was replay the past five years of his life on loop as he dozed, searching for any other inconsistencies he may have missed.

The problem was, though their relationship may not have been as clear-cut as most, they were comfortable. Oftentimes too comfortable to try changing anything between them. But, even so, their bond was undeniable. They would always be each other’s person no matter what. And Mydei, though he refused to admit it even in the silence of his own room, knew deep down that his heart was already full of Phainon’s *everything.*

Mydei blinked awake far too early the following morning. He rubbed at his fogged-over eyes and checked his teleslate. *Curtain-Fall Hour, 3:17 AM.*

Looks like he spent the better part of the night slumped over on Phainon's stoop. If it hadn’t rained so hard, one of the neighbors probably would’ve reported him for public intoxication or something. Not all Okhemans were close-minded like the elders, but Mydei didn’t want to take any unnecessary risks.

Stepping out onto the street, Mydei kept his eyes focused straight ahead and didn’t turn back. His boots made a gross, slick sound on the marble pathways as he trudged back up through the mountain passage. Okhema smelled like Antila flowers in the early spring, and the fragrance wafted from every corner where the petals had washed up.

Hardly anyone was out and about at this hour, and the few indifferent businessmen and drunkards who passed by paid him no mind. For the first time in weeks, Mydei didn’t mind being overlooked. He was perfectly content experiencing this moment on his own.

The walk back home through the drenched streets had left him feeling oddly refreshed. Mydei was always partial to borderline boiling baths himself, but maybe the impromptu cold shower had its benefits after all. Those long hours of reminiscing on all the best and worst moments they shared throughout the years felt like a sudden clarity washing over him.

None of this was “sudden”. It had been there all along. All of it.

Phainon’s terrible sense of self-esteem. His evasive tendencies. His fear of confrontation. His self-sacrificing nature.

Even the virus that had transferred from his PC to Mydei’s had been there throughout it all. And perhaps that was reason enough to keep going down

this path, to figure out just what untold secrets lay beyond the cage of wires and circuit boards.

Mydei was now reminded of a particular conversation they shared in their final semester of undergraduate studies. It was during one of their countless outings across campus, just a mundane lunch date shared on a sparsely populated lawn. He was preoccupied with his meat lover's salad, courtesy of Phainon, when said man cleared his throat. Mydei met his eyes, curious, and he just grinned sheepishly.

"Professor Anaxa proposed a unique assignment to us today. I've been trying to figure it out on my own all this time, but I just don't think I can do it."

An assignment that had stumped Phainon? Well, that piqued his interest.

"Tell me about it."

After a moment of hesitation, he complied with the request. "We were discussing post-graduation aspirations in the lecture today. I guess Anaxa just can't *wait* to get rid of us, because he's demanding an essay about our own future plans now."

The future, huh? That was the impossible task that Phainon had yet to conquer? Somehow, though he didn't exactly know why, that didn't really surprise Mydei at all.

"Sometimes…when I'm really in a bind, I think about what you would do, Mydei. How would you tackle this insurmountable dilemma in a way that made everyone happy?"

What an unreasonable demand. No one could ever make a choice that satisfied everyone. Especially not an average university student who only wanted to graduate and find a decent job that suited their best interests. But the way Phainon looked to him as a support system clenched at his heart painfully. He couldn't let him down now.

At Phainon's expectant, revering glance, Mydei took a breath and began to speak. “I don’t know about you, but my goals have always been set in stone. All my life, I have always regarded archival work as my ideal career. So…I’ve decided that I will be applying to the graduate school next year.”

Phainon seemed to stir at that. Reflexively, he shot forward to look Mydei dead in the eyes. “Really? That’s quite the impressive goal you’ve got there.”

“The Kremnos of days past may lie in ruins, but the spirit of our people will never be doused out. I want to preserve these fragments for future generations to come.” Mydei has long resolved to serve his community to his best abilities. This was the only path he had known in this life, and he would do his utmost to see it through to the end. Still, he was curious to know how the people closest to him saw it. “Do you think it suits me?”

Phainon scoffed. “Are you kidding? No one is more suited to this line of work than you. From the very first time we met, you made it clear that this was your passion. That’s exactly why I had to silence anyone that questioned you.”

“It’s a truly admirable goal to pursue. Of all your strengths, ‘tenacity’ is perhaps the one I find most admirable of all.” Phainon smiled wide, and the sun paled in comparison. “May your dreams always come true, Mydeimos. I’ll be there cheering you on each step of the way.”

And he had. He *always* had. So Mydei was once again resolved to see his chosen path through to the end.

“Phainon has always been by my side, just as he promised. So now it must be my turn to fulfill his wishes instead.”

Returning to the dense silence of his apartment was a sobering affair in its own right, but Mydei had better things to do than wallow. He ignored the golden keys on the counter glinting with mockery, opting to strip himself down to the nude and towel off his damp body instead. Now dressed in

simple nightwear (no way was he going anywhere else today, not when his bed was actively luring him into its warm embrace), Mydei made his way into the office adjacent to his bedroom once more.

The towel slapped against his skin as he finished drying off his long and unruly locks, and slowly, the little virtual creature on his desktop opened its beady eyes.

“You have a sleep mode now? I swear you didn’t do that before,” Mydei commented lightly, sitting down in the chair to examine his golden fairy-elf-thing up close. Its wings had started to flap in excitement, probably waiting for Mydei to power its beloved mouse back on.

He did just that, and sure enough, the creature latched on like a bloodthirsty leech. Well, as long as it calmed down and stopped mass opening his password-protected work documents for fun, who was he to complain? As it turned out, even a computer virus that was prone to tantrums was decent company on lonely nights.

He entertained the creature for a while longer, observing its jerky movements and dead eyes without a word. It watched him dutifully all the while, hugging its hostage tight. Mydei huffed out a tired laugh and dimmed the lights before treading out of the room to get some proper rest.

This time, he left the mouse on.

Chapter 5: Through the Line

When Mydei woke that same afternoon, his apartment was still cloaked in a layer of darkness. He had previously buried himself in a warm pocket between his sheets, but somewhere in the middle of his sleep cycle he had twisted himself out into the cold embrace of his room. He felt no more rested than he had earlier that morning, and his sinuses were all congested after prolonged exposure to the elements. The long shadows cast on the walls threatened to swallow him once again, dragging him back to the realm of dreams. It was only the sliver of light peering in through Mydei's curtains that caught his eye, tugging him away from rest once more.

As any other person of the modern era would, he immediately rolled over to check his teleslate. As usual, a number of notifications—several messages from friends, a whole list of inquiries from his employees on GoldMail that he was definitely not dealing with now, monthly bank statements that he had no use for, etcetera—flooded the screen as soon as he pressed the power button. But none of those mattered at all when he finally saw what awaited him at the very bottom of the list. It was the oldest notification displayed there, received just after sunrise.

Missed Call

Phainon - 5:05 AM

There he was. Finally, he was returning to seek Mydei out once more.

Phainon was coming back to him.

Without even thinking he instantly called back, letting the sensation of pure *relief* consume him instead. Of course he was still angry, frustrated beyond belief at both Phainon's evasive tendencies as well as his own inability to breach through to him. He felt too much too soon after waking, and his mind had become a jumbled mess.

But still. *Still.*

The line rang for a few painful moments and Mydei waited with bated breath. And then—

Click.

“Phainon.” Mydei felt as if the air had been knocked clean out of his lungs.

The other side of the line was quiet, a faint hum reverberating back with little else to go on. It must have been a fan running in the background, like the one in Phainon’s room that was always turned to the highest setting, just because he didn’t fare well with the heat. A moment passed, and then a few shuffling sounds overlapped, as if someone were rolling over in bed. Had he also slept in for once? Was his schedule also thrown completely off by this mess just as Mydei’s was? Did he also feel as if he could just reach out and feel that warmth of smooth skin against his own, as if they were in bed together, just close enough to touch as they always were before?

Again, he mumbled out, “Phainon. Are you there?”

Were you thinking of me? Have you been frustrated with this silence between us, too?

There were so many things Mydei wanted to say, but none of the words ever came out correctly. Words of encouragement became declarations of war, affirmations were discarded for stilted sighs, even the love he wished to seal into Phainon’s lips like a bruise faded before he could ever hope to speak them into existence. As usual, he would just wait for Phainon to say something first. That’s how it always was. Even if it shouldn’t have been.

So Mydei remained in that fragile bubble, so exhausted from chasing all the time yet still unable to remedy anything. He would have thought the line had gone dead if not for the subtle background noises still bleeding through from the other side. As time passed and the fan’s blades spun around and around, he felt that dizzying sensation in his head again. Maybe it would be better to just sleep it off after all.

But then, despite it all, a breath. Mydei’s eyelids fluttered as he pulled the teleslate nearer, soaking in each disturbance he could.

“Mydei,” Phainon’s greeting was gentle, just a whisper. Yet it was enough to wake him for good. *“It’s…really been a while since I've heard your morning voice. Way to get a guy all worked up first thing in the morning.”*

“Looks like someone’s back to their usual self.” Mydei’s response was as irritated as it was fond. How did this insufferable man who lived for getting under his skin always manage to make such a wreck out of his heart?

“Haha, what's that supposed to mean? I'm just happy to finally catch a break after these past few weeks. It's not that big of a deal.”

“We’ve hardly talked at all since this mess began. That *is* a big deal. I know you like to act clueless, but we both know the truth, Phainon.”

“...Do we have to do this now?”

So he was still running. Too bad Mydei had long grown tired of this routine. Whether Phainon was willing to cooperate or not, he was going to latch on and drag him back.

He gritted out, “Consider yourself lucky that I got to you first instead of Cyrene. You're steadily racking up enough grudges against you to last a lifetime.”

“Look, I'm really sorry about all of this. I never meant to make you all worry! I just—”

“You just *what?* Thought that pulling a disappearing act would suddenly make all of your friends stop caring about your wellbeing? Do you even hear yourself?” Mydei had officially had enough of the calm charade. He would never be indifferent to these things like so many people in this city were. Phainon understood that, he had to. But again—silence.

In his absence, Mydei continued, “You never want to talk. I don’t expect that to change overnight. But there will always be people behind you who care. No matter how stubborn you may be or how your insecurities warp your view, you cannot be blind to the world if you ever want to save it.”

“Save…the world…?” Phainon audibly swallowed, shifting in place like he had grown uncomfortable. *“I’m no hero, Mydeimos. You know that better than anyone.”*

“Then stop acting like one.”

“Mydei…”

This conversation was getting them absolutely nowhere. The consequences of having two stubborn people in a relationship, he supposed. They were rarely at odds when it truly mattered, so for things to escalate to this point… Surely an intervention would have to take place sooner or later. And if Phainon needed another day to digest his words, then so be it. Mydei had already become an expert in the art of waiting.

Even after chewing him out over the teleslate, Mydei could still manage that gentle tone reserved just for him. “Get some rest, Phainon. We'll see each other soon enough.”

He hung up before Phainon could start sniveling over the line. Mostly because Mydei wasn’t sure he could handle hearing it. His resolve had nearly wavered once already, and once was more than enough.

He naturally gravitated towards his office in the aftermath of that stifling conversation. The door was ajar and only a small amount of light poured through, enough to see that the creature was once again dozing away. Strange. What exactly did a virus need an idle animation for? Unless it had ripped assets straight from one of Phainon’s games over the long years spent hiding in his hard drive. Mydei didn’t know the logistics of any of this, nor did he care enough to find out what these irrelevant details meant. Unless a deep-dive into computer science could solve all his problems, he wasn’t interested.

As Mydei sat at the desk, crossing his legs and slumping his cheek into his fist, something kept vaguely nagging at him. He gripped the mouse in his right hand and startled the small creature awake with a few gentle taps. It blinked slowly, as an actual living person would do upon waking, and then seemed to perk up once it realized who had disturbed its sleep.

“I guess you slept in too, huh.” He entertained the creature’s antics for another minute, allowing it to hold the mouse pointer before reclaiming it for his own use. It initially refused to let go, but upon realizing that Mydei could, in fact, click and drag it away like any other program file, it relented. It didn’t seem to like being controlled much.

Feeling somewhat satisfied with his minor victory, Mydei continued, “That wasn’t so hard, now was it? Just submit yourself to my commands and everything will work out between us. That’s how it should be between us __”

He cut himself off abruptly. In the middle of his casual taunting, the green light of his webcam had been switched on. He leaned closer to the screen, examining the built-in camera lens with furrowed brows. No background applications had been opened to his knowledge, but the situation still felt wrong. Was he being *recorded* now? It was one thing for a virus to go snooping through his files and personal information and whatnot, but now it seemed to be targeting his physical body as well.

“That wasn’t on before. You did this.” Mydei pointed an accusatory finger towards the lens. “Just how advanced is your programming? And why are you always so…glitchy?”

He tapped the screen pointedly, ignoring whatever smudge marks may or may not have appeared. The creature was watching, though its movements were also slower, more lethargic than before. It was just like when he opened too many tabs at once and tried running his GoldMail in the background; operating too many systems simultaneously caused the computer to slow. The creature clearly worked in the same way.

“Interesting.” He filed that piece of information away for a later date.

Since there was nothing to be done about being watched, Mydei decided to endure it and continue on as if nothing had happened. The creature could watch and listen to him all it wanted to, but he was still a functioning member of society with work to do.

First on the agenda was going over the material access forms that were submitted in the e-portal overnight. He was usually on top of his work and managed the requests system well enough that his employees wouldn’t come bothering him about missing documents and accumulated fee errors (or so he wished, but reality was never so kind).

Those who frequented the archives were either scholars or university students conducting research independently, and more often than not they busied themselves with the newer, easily digested materials. The special collections were less frequently populated and only advanced Kremnoan researchers tended to request access. Only a single person had browsed those antiquated texts within the past month, after all. It was a relatively slow time for foot traffic, given the changing of seasons and recent start of a new academic semester.

After approving of the whopping three new requests, he then shifted his attention to the previously overlooked messages awaiting him on GoldMail.

> From *Godshield_Krateros@GoldMail.net*, 09:05, Subject: RE:RE:RE:RE: Local files?

> From *strifegodabove@GoldMail.net*, 11:10, Subject: New Job Listing – UPDATED; (Company event req.!!!)

> From *Chiro_09@GoldMail.net*, 08:22, Subject: Processing app. finalized

Nothing unexpected, mostly the same technical issues that were always circulating around the system—help with cloud services, the social networking manager working on job listing to fill their recent runaway employee’s spot, another request to hold a social event to keep up morale in the workplace. He would have gone into autopilot mode usually when it came to these daily concerns. However, that final message managed to catch Mydei’s attention. He clicked on it, tensing as he read through its contents.

Dear Mr. Mydeimos,

As per Ms. Empousa’s previous messages, the processing request for a reclassification of ITEM #KL3700159 has been resolved as of 08:00 this morning. As per your revision of the anonymous request form, it now resides in the section LITERATURE – FICTION. This is the final update regarding this request.

Sincerely,

Chironome

KCCA Secretary

And suddenly everything fell into place. If memory served him right, ITEM #KL300159 was a novel by a controversial Kremnoan author who lived over half a century ago. Mydei himself had not entertained the thought of reading it, and he hardly would have remembered its existence at all if not for a conversation he happened to overhear several weeks ago, before this whole fiasco had even begun.

As he was doing the regular rounds in the evening, readjusting the temperature control gauges, reviewing the latest shipment reports and sorting through all the requested document boxes for the next week, a sudden, high-pitched shriek interrupted his peaceful flow.

“—I’ve already told you multiple times that this isn’t what I wanted! You’re wasting everyone’s time by handing out inappropriate materials like this!”

“Miss Julia, if you would kindly lower your voice…”

Though he rarely interacted with guests himself, Mydei was curious about the ruckus reverberating through the halls. He peeked his head around the corner, his eyes landing on the fuming young scholar currently waving a book around madly in the archival coordinator’s face. Judging by his employee’s expression, said book was probably a priceless artifact from the special collections. Mydei clutched the doorframe to physically restrain

himself from intervening. Nikador knows how Empousa controlled her temper under such scrutiny.

“Why? It’s not like anyone else is hanging around these dusty shelves anyway!” The lady huffed, pushing her hair away with a puff of air. “I’m running out of time on this project, and then this happens at this absolute worst time. I’m so, so doomed.”

“If you would just tell me what’s the matter, I can try my best to resolve the issue.”

Empousa calmly reached for the book, but the scholar yanked it out of reach and began flipping through the pages, pointing furiously at the tabbed pages that had offended her the most.

“I already told you—it’s this stupid book! When I requested a box full of historical legends, this is absolutely *not* what I had in mind!” She then slammed the cover closed and jabbed a finger at the classification sticker on the protective film. “Amphorean Legends? What a joke. This is just some dead geezer’s crappy delusions packed as a novel. He should’ve thrown himself into the Theosphere Lake sooner and spared the world of this nonsense!”

How heartless… Though not unexpected. This scholar clearly had no respect for their establishment at all. Still, the weary Empousa took it in stride.

“Would you mind informing me what exactly is the issue with this classification?”

The scholar narrowed her eyes, drawing nearer. She looked as if Empousa had spit on her. “It’s like categorizing the poems of Verginia under ‘Court Documents’ just because she happened to uphold the Imperator’s Law. If you cannot discern actual history from works of fiction, you have no place in any library!”

“The protagonist is no hero! He might try to act like one, but everyone knows the truth. To consider this a ‘legend’ is a disgrace to the true heroes

of Amphoreus’ past!”

Empousa handled the book delicately and filled out the form as the guest heckled her. And once it was complete, Mydei decided it was only fair to politely show Miss Julia the door after such a spirited display. That was basically the end of the matter; since that day, no one had accessed the special collections. Mydei still did his daily tasks, reorganizing when needed, but his employees were at least self-sufficient enough to handle most of the clerical work on their own. He hardly paid any attention to Empousa’s prior message requesting help with the reclassification system, deciding to just forward it to Chironome.

The reclassification itself was still of no importance to him. But that word, “hero”... That was exactly what had been bothering him this whole time. Mydei had previously said it to Phainon, accusing him of the exact same thing—*pretending to be a hero.* It was a small lead. But a lead, nonetheless.

He bypassed the portal and went straight to the administrative site to reserve the book. Then, he sent a message to Chironome requesting that she place it on his desk before he arrived at the archives that evening.

“I’ll learn the truth in my own way. Just as I always have,” he promised the creature before setting out.

The archives were always pretty desolate on Friday evenings. Most students in the holy city were more keen on getting drunk at whatever festival held in Phagousa’s name was currently taking place in the bathhouses than researching millennia-old documents from the wasteland known as

Kremnos. Not that it bothered Mydei; the fewer guests that needed catering to, the more work he got done.

Chironome was at the service desk when he entered, and she waved hello before dutifully returning to her ledgers. The downside of having so few employees was that everyone needed to compensate for the unfulfilled roles around the center. She was primarily a secretary, but also worked in digitizing many of the untouched collections alongside Mydei. He considered himself a more “hands-on” director than most, and often filled any vacant position when needed. Anything to keep the center running smoothly.

His office was a small space tucked away from the main hub of the archives. It was quiet there, save for the ticking of a clock mounted up on the wall and the hum of electricity surging through the walls into the yellow lights blinking overhead. It wasn’t the best space, nor the most aesthetically pleasing. Not that Mydei particularly cared either way. The way he saw it, this world was only just surviving by its own will, sinking its fangs into sweet illusions of the past that were not yet strong enough to conceal the ruins underfoot.

The architecture of the modern day was a far cry from the timeless marble behemoths towering over Okhema’s landscape, but the city simply lacked the resources to reproduce the past in such elegant forms. Besides, with the IPC always lurking in the shadows, ready to prey upon those who reveal their vulnerabilities, Amphoreus’ leaders were quite wary of accepting foreign aid. So, a complete restoration was virtually impossible, and they could only adapt and move forward.

But if an artificial sun could burn bright enough to light humanity’s way forward, so could the small, flickering lamp in the corner of his office.

It was bright enough to make out the cooling documents neatly aligned in a stack on his desk, as well as his assortment of writing utensils. And there it was, just as Chironome had promised: *Origin of Primordial Chaos* – A Novel of Divine Acclaim by Kryptos, Devout Acolyte to Kephale. A blue leather-bound book estimated to have been originally written in the 4412th year of the current era. Despite the rather rough handling it endured earlier

that month, not a single scratch was left on it. Mydei paid the out-of-house conservators too well for his artifacts to show signs of wear.

He opened to the first page, and immediately suppressed the urge to groan.

> “The thirteenth returns, and remains as the first.
>
> Fire and light are the embodiment of sin.
>
> The visage lost, the blood lost, the soul lost… What is finally lost is the name.
>
> Life is resurrected, perishes, and then returns once again in this primordial blaze.
>
> The one who carries out the sacrifice is also part of the sacrificial offering.
>
> Thus we will begin with the original sin.
>
> To deliver the fire, we killed ourselves every time.”
>
> — Words of Unknown Origin

It began with an epigraph from the “Golden Scapegoat’s Mutterings”, one of the oldest surviving collections from the Era Bellica that every history major had encountered at least once in their academic careers. Mydei himself was very familiar with the contents, so he could immediately tell that this Kyros had gone through the entire collection and cut and pasted everything down to a seven-line bastardized amalgamation of the original poems. *What a great start this was off to.*

Reading through, the novel’s premise was clearly an unusual take on the legends of old. Rather than featuring a group of Chrysos Heirs, the flame-chasing heroes were instead represented as demigod children of the titans

who undertook a trial of divinity. Kyros held no faith in the prophecies of Janusopolis, citing past fabrications that shamed all children of Kephale. He only trusted in the historical records that survived from ancient times, and the fallen titan he held so dear.

The protagonist, Khaos, was born of Kephale atop Dawncloud. But the mystic Thirteenth Titan stripped him of his power and memories, casting him from the mountain's summit to a humble village at the world's edge. The following chapters described Khaos' transformation from an innocent child to an empty shell once his hometown was consumed by the black tide, and then a competent leader of the Flame-Chase into a broken idol as he destroyed his own world.

An interesting concept, if not convoluted; the execution across the pages was in a similar state, judging by the footnotes overflowing with any and every reference known to man, from historical accounts to folk tales to the author's own musings. Still, Mydei read all through the evening, until the archives closed for the night and he slipped the book into a protective carrying case for the commute back to his apartment. Each time he hit a red light or allowed a pedestrian to cross the street, he couldn't help glancing over at it with a sense of longing.

Upon arriving home, Mydei holed himself up in his spare room, the one with the fewest distractions. He pored over each word with conviction, not letting a single phrase go to waste. And several hours later, he had arrived at the very last page of the (rather short) novel. It was on this page that he discovered the crux of the entire story.

> The boy once called Khaos stood before the end of the world he had vowed to save.
>
> "You are no child of Kephale! Our beloved Sky Father could never bear such a disgrace as you!" The ghosts of days past seemed to understand him better than anyone. Indeed, Khaos was no Deliverer. He was no hero. He was no paragon of love as Kephale had been. But they would all forget by the twilight hour's ordain.

“Khaos, my kindest friend.” That Mene’s dying gasp was the first he ever felt. The sun carved himself from the moon’s shadow. Her body split and golden light flowed through his splintered veins. From his shell he hatched a winged God greater than any human, demigod or titan who stood in his way. Time was no more.

Now without name, he tread the long night in search of dawn’s pale light.

“Nameless One” That Scylla and Japetus had called him.

“Dux Liberatio” That Eunomia had called him.

“False Sun” That Triptolemus and Maia had called him.

“Shadowed Blade” That Phoebe and Cytherea had called him.

One by one, all the realms of this world fell silent in awe of his fury.

Ocean and Earth to monstrosity.

Law to an unreached dream.

Reason and Trickery to a blade.

Passage and Romance to flame.

And then, from ones he held so dear:

“Lord Erikepaios, you needn’t sacrifice yourself!” That Iris plummeted into a pool of boiling gold. The beast’s wings were melted away. Sky was no more.

“Lord Erikepaios, oh why?” That Prosperina sank into a sea of wilted flowers. The dragon’s bones were dissolved into ash. Death was no more.

“Lord Erikepaios, you are no friend of mine!” That Phobos fell into a river of souls. The lion’s pelt was pierced from behind. Strife was no more.

The boy once called Khaos stood before the Thirteenth he had vowed to destroy.

“You are no child of Kephale. No titan could bear such hatred as you.” He spoke for his ears alone. Indeed, he was no Deliverer. He was no hero. He was Destruction.

And with Thirteen, became One.

And then it ended, just like that. Just as quiet as the old world was said to have been in its final moments. It left Mydei with a strange emptiness inside, a hole somewhere in his abdomen, just below his heart. As such a practical man, he knew it was just a novel; a dying fantasy concocted by a Kremnoan who denied his own heritage to worship a nonexistent god. The author may have seen it as Kephale’s will to spread this gospel—but even Kryptos himself acknowledged that his work was merely a novel and not a holy text to prostrate before.

Still. It felt right, in a way. Was that fallen hero described in the tale not the spitting image of his very own computer virus, the floating creature with porcelain skin cracking away to reveal a sea of molten gold? Was it not something also born of the titans’ wrath, a being that could hardly

communicate after throwing itself into the flame? The similarities were too great to ignore. Mydei was convinced that, until proven otherwise, the creature must have been inspired by that very novel. That was the only explanation.

He laid the book gently into the case and retreated to his office once more. The creature, now a peculiar shade of dull yellow as opposed to its usual golden glow, was already listening. It must have anticipated his return. Or maybe he was reading too much into everything and this was just one big waste of time. Mydei was used to experiencing setbacks wherever he went, but not once did he despair and sit by idly while there was still a chance to enact change.

Mydei stood tall over the desk, palms flat on its surface as he leaned close to the screen, close enough for his hair to brush over the creature's shattered form.

I want to see you for all that you are. Is that so strange?

"Khaos," he said. Demanded, more like. The creature didn't blink. And then —

■■■■■: ■N■o■■■Na■m■e■

LordMydei: It's yours if you want it

LordMydei: Not "δ_me13"

■■■■■: ■■■P■a■st■■

■■■■■: ■N■o■■M■or■e■■■

So it wasn’t an exact match to the novel. He was almost expecting that answer, though. And at least another truth had come to light through this interaction: the virus could respond to real-time audio prompts almost like a virtual assistant. Its AI must have been extremely well-programmed. Strange, given its purpose was to steal information. Were human voices counted in that?

He spoke again, a little muted this time. “I won’t force you then. If you want to be a nameless fairy or whatever, be my guest.”

The creature didn’t react again. And perhaps that would have been a complete dead end with nowhere else to go, the final match burnt to cinders in the cold. But something was still itching right at Mydei’s tongue. What could it be? He didn’t have anything left.

…*Unless.*

A thought suddenly appeared in Mydei’s head. He had no idea where it came from, but it just made sense, in a way. Like his brain was connecting two virtually unrelated puzzle pieces and they somehow fit perfectly into place.

“How about…Khaslana?” he choked out, almost against his better judgment. It was another inexplicable reaction to an arbitrary phrase he had never once thought of before. But it was a telling one, especially due to the creature’s simultaneous reaction.

It seemed to twitch at once, just a little tremor in the wings. But then it spread, and soon enough its whole body seized up into an uncontrollable rippling of dark splotches.

He had inadvertently triggered another tantrum—though this one was far more reminiscent of an episode of panicking than rage. Could a virus simulate such human emotions to a perfect degree without much prompting? And moreover, were there rehabilitation programs available for this sort of thing? Mydei didn’t think there were any therapists for computer

programs out there, but maybe if he could just get into its systems and find a mod that worked…

In this midst of his disjointed rumination, the creature seemed to calm at once, as if taken by a bout of solace in between the suffering.

■■■■■: ■Yo■u■■

■■■■■: ■■Me■mor■y?■

LordMydei: Memory? Storage space?

LordMydei: Maybe the command wasn’t clear

LordMydei: Khaslana. Your name.

■■■■■: ■■■■■!!!

■■■■■: ■■■■■!!!

■■■■■: ■■■■■!!!

■■■■■: ■■■■■!!!

■■■■■: ■■■■■!!!

“I don’t know what I did, but…” Mydei furrowed his brows as the creature bobbed up and down with a burst of energy. He hadn’t seen it so active in

quite a while. “Clearly that name means *something.* It has to.”

LordMydei: Khaslana, speak plainly.

■■■■■: ■■T■r■y■■b■ut■■■

■■■■■: ■F■i■re■■■■■

So there was some kind of existing firewall preventing the creature from exercising full autonomy. Interesting. He was planning to see just how efficient its voice recognition was, perhaps acting more like the digital assistant on his teleslate that was more equipped to handle advanced tasks. Bubbles the Chimera was pretty rudimentary as far as desktop assistants went, only finding a use when it came to composing messages or locating documents on his computer. He didn’t even have a voice recognition feature. Of course, Mydei would never prefer a virus to his loyal companion. He was just curious.

He spent the rest of the night poking around at Khaslana and trying to dish out different task commands. It seemed to slow as time progressed, however, so Mydei decided to let the dozing little virus sleep in peace, while he attempted to do the same.

But at the strike of midnight, right as Mydei was beginning to sink his head into his pillow and close his eyes, his teleslate began buzzing from over on his nightstand. He laid still for a second, silently asking the titans for patience, before sitting up once more to see just who was disturbing him at this late hour.

Ha, as if there were ever any doubt.

Phainon: I’m sorry

Phainon: I never wanted to hurt you and everyone else, Mydei. But it was wrong of me to dismiss all of your concerns.

Phainon: I won’t let this happen again.

Phainon: You don’t need to reply, just know that I do want to talk things through

Phainon: So let me know when the time is right, and I’ll be there

“How absurd.” Phainon’s eye-rolling antics were nothing new, but he had reached a new level of irritating since making the decision to test out the whole runaway pet routine. He really was lucky that it was Mydei who had to deal with him. Cyrene and Hyacine were going to have a field day when he finally came crawling back home.

Mydei: No need for all the dramatics

Mydei: We’ll talk tomorrow

Phainon: Are you sure? That’s sooner than anticipated

Mydei: Yes.

Mydei: Now stop being so weird

Mydei: I liked you better when you were annoying me to death

Phainon: Haha really??

Phainon: (^.^)

Mydei could almost hear his relieved laugh. It made his bedroom feel less suffocatingly lonely. If his dreams were filled with nothing but Phainon again, at least they would be sweet ones this time.

Since making the decision to cohabitate his own computer with the golden fairy virus, Mydei had, regrettably, grown used to its antics.

Khaslana—he had begrudgingly started calling his computer virus by name—disliked being shut down. *Immensely.* Nothing unusual for a virus that fed off system data, but it was the creature's reaction that most bothered Mydei. If he so much as hovered his mouse over the POWER OFF button, it would enter what he had dubbed "Self-Destruct Mode" and begin glitching violently in much the same way as Phainon's possessed character sprite once had. Mydei, for all his efforts, had stopped trying to figure out the purpose of its programming and decided to just take it all in stride.

Was it impractical? The whole situation was from the beginning. Anyone else would've hurried over to the local appliances store and begged them to save their computer. But there he was, keeping Khaslana cooped up in his computer like a golden baby chick under an incubator. The goal was still to locate the source of whatever had infected Phainon's computer, of course. That had never changed. But who could've expected this outcome? He'd certainly never entertained the idea of keeping a piece of malware as a pet.

Oh well. Despite everything, Mydei had to admit that for a computer virus most definitely carting a spyware program, his little fairy friend was almost endearing.

■■■■■: ■■C■■a■■■n■t■

■■■■■: ■T■o■u■■ch■■■

Mydei, deciding to play philanthropist for his seemingly touch-starved computer virus, rolled the mouse over its little body until the pointer turned into a hand icon. The creature reached out as always, almost desperate to latch on.

“Here, you can have it as long as I’m not busy.”

■■■■■: ■■Hold■■■

“You even managed a full word this time. Congratulations.” Mydei ran a hand through his unruly mane and leaned back in his chair. “Somehow I’ve ended up with two clingy ones who are always searching for attention.”

The more time passed, the greater the similarities between Phainon and the creature appeared. Or maybe that was just his loneliness talking. Was he searching for loose threads that didn’t really exist out of desperation? Maybe. In truth, there were only superficial overlaps connecting Phainon and the creature through a character from a highly dubious 500 year old novel.

So what if Phainon and Khaos both embodied tragic heroism and had a strong, possessive edge? So what if Khaslana bore the same scathing, golden wounds as Khaos? There wasn't much else to go on as a collective, only superficial qualities that incited confirmation bias.

But in a way, wasn't it all connected somehow? Bypassing circumstantial evidence, it was a fact that the virus had begun as Phainon's problem alone. Weeks of futile research on the World Wound Web had shown that it was either an incredibly niche program originating from some untouchable corner of invisible darknets, or it was already living in Phainon's computer when he first got it in his childhood. Since Khaslana had only decided to show itself now, there was no real way to verify the truth.

Secondly, it had to be said that Khaslana didn't begin as the creature it was now. The first time it visibly manifested onscreen, it had taken the form of Kephale—named after the very same titan that Khaos represented. That couldn't have been a coincidence.

It was hard to tell with how pixelated the creature was, not to mention how mangled its body had become, but from certain angles—maybe squinting or closing an eye and leaning close enough to brush his nose against the screen—it may have resembled Phainon. Just a smidge.

Not that Khaslana was a replacement for him, not in the slightest. While Phainon was a man full of smiles and sunshine akin to the breath of life itself, this creature was just composed of data. It could hardly communicate, much less follow its own programming. There was a chance its behavior was just mimicking Phainon's to begin with. That could be what Mydei saw in it all along—just an echo of sentience that never belonged to it in the first place.

But thinking back to *Origin of Primordial Chaos* now, one thought replayed in his mind: "*When one appeared, the other was cast into the fire. A vicious cycle of sacrifice was all he knew.*" That was also true to reality, wasn't it? In Phainon's absence, the creature had found Mydei. In the absence of answers, Khaos found him too.

Now that Phainon was finally coming back to him, what would happen next?

Consequences be damned, Mydei was desperate to see him again, to confirm that he was real. Being left alone in the dark for so long with a cheap imitation of Phainon onscreen wasn't enough anymore. He needed to feel the subtle warmth of his skin instead of a monitor, hear that boyish laugh without the crackles of a faulty teleslate connection interrupting them, look deep into his azure gaze and say *It's you, isn't it?*

The message on GoldMail arrived rather unexpectedly at the Lucid Hour's first quint. Rather than another set of complaints and service requests from his employees, however, Mydei had received an update from the Trash King Quest Online customer support team. Strange. He hadn't contacted them for over a week, didn't even bother to follow up with a half-hearted "thanks." after the last failed intervention. No way they were actually putting any effort into his requests.

> Dear LordMydei600,
>
> The Trash King Quest Online team has received your previous assistance forms regarding user DawnMaker496.
>
> After careful review, we have determined that a systemwide error automatically flagged the active user who interacted with the following non-interactive virtual items in the map location Dawncloud: DAWN DEVICE. Illegal references have been reset and no future error reports are expected regarding this issue.
>
> The suspension of user DawnMaker496 has been deemed unlawful by fault of map irregularities and access to this account has been restored. More information regarding account suspension overturns can be found here.
>
> Please contact us at TKQ_support@GoldMail.net if you have any more questions.

Thank you,

Trash King Quest Online Customer Support

“Systemwide error? Illegal references?” Mydei squinted at the screen. There was no denying that Khaslana had corrupted the character sprite’s core data, leading to errors exclusively on Phainon’s end that resulted in a suspension. But now the support team was claiming they were the ones at fault? Yeah, right. What kind of a one-in-a-million chance would that be? They clearly didn’t know what they were doing at all.

He sighed and leaned back in his chair, ignoring the consecutive creaks from both the chair and his back. His mother always said he was born not just with her beauty but impeccable posture as well, but that did nothing for the ache he constantly felt beneath his skin. Such was the life of an office worker, he supposed.

“Whatever. I should just be glad that Phainon’s account was restored. That’s what I’ve been after since the beginning.”

This was the perfect opportunity, after all.

No time like the present for a long overdue reunion.

Mydei: Come over ASAP

Phainon: Oh?

Phainon: Usually you send me a heartfelt “Good morning❤” message first. I’m a little disappointed…

Phainon: But if you want to skip to the good stuff then I’m fine with that too!

Mydei: I have no idea what kind of nonsense you’re talking about now but whatever.

Mydei: There are a few things we need to discuss

Phainon: Are there really though?

Mydei: Don’t start.

Mydei: Look, something else happened after your TKQ character was resurrected.

Phainon: Is that really important right now?

Phainon: I mean, talking like we’re in a horror movie like this kind of kills the mood

Mydei: It’s important. Come quickly.

Phainon: For you? Always!

Phainon: ¬‿¬

Mydei: ?

The twenty-minute wait for him to come over was almost more excruciating than the past several weeks had been. He couldn't keep his eyes off the clock, slowly counting the seconds as his hands tensed around the clunky armrests on his chair. It wasn't often that he got like this.

Despite the fact that meeting Phainon again was Mydei's greatest desire, his body seemed to fear it just as equally. A complete nonsense reaction, feeling such soul-crushing anxiety over meeting his boyfriend of five whole years. They would be fine. They always were, no matter how tight money got for Phainon, how many sleepless nights Mydei spent on graduate school assignments, how many job rejections they'd both been faced with or the countless other ways fate decided to mess with them.

Mydei already scolded him anyway. It was about time they had a proper heart-to-heart.

At just past nine in the morning, Mydei heard a frazzled jumbling of keys and the lock on his front door give way. He inhaled sharply, trying his best to appear casual as Phainon's sneakers squeaked on the tile floor.

It's just Phainon, his mind supplied unhelpfully. That wasn't right, though. It was never *just* Phainon. As nonchalant as Mydei may have appeared outwardly, his heart pounded inside with overwhelming force.

Phainon entered the office carrying a latte from their favorite café and the scent of fresh bread with him. He wore a wide smile as he met Mydei's eyes, crinkling his own as he drew near. Mydei had to physically restrain himself from shooting up out of his chair and tackling the other man to the ground.

"Good morning, Mydei!" Phainon exclaimed, awful cheery for an early morning. He stopped between Mydei's thighs, practically glowing as he leaned in for a hug. And how could Mydei refuse? Just seeing him was everything he wanted and more.

Phainon always gave the best hugs. His embrace was just as warm as Mydei remembered, firm yet snug enough to melt into completely. It was tempting to pin him in place and refuse to let go until he groveled on his knees for forgiveness. But Phainon pulled away uncharacteristically soon, leaving a searing kiss upon Mydei's pulse before sipping from his cup with an innocent grin.

Mydei, flustered enough to blush up to the tips of his ears, swallowed harshly and pretended not to be affected.

"What a sight for sore eyes you are. To think I would've missed out on seeing you today if I hadn't quit my job." Phainon laughed to himself, eyeing Mydei's shifting form closely over the rim of his cup. "Though I must say, you don't normally wear so many layers. I can only picture your conspicuous body in my mind."

Well. Ignoring the lechery spilling from his tongue, he wasn't exactly wrong.

"That's because you're wearing my shirt."

"Am I?" Phainon mimed inspecting his shirt, as if he couldn't tell based on the cropped cut alone. He never wore that style even when they were alone. "Huh, You must have left it the last time you stayed over. It still smells like your fancy date night cologne."

Judging by the pleased smirk growing on his lips, Phainon was clearly referring to the last time Mydei pushed him into his mattress and brought him to the Nether Realm and back. Most of that night was a blur by now for both of them. It made sense though. Mydei's morning routine demanded a high-intensity run before breakfast, so leaving his shirts behind once in a while was inevitable. He didn't know that Phainon wore them, however. Or that he didn't even bother to wash them.

Mydei, already sitting stiffly with his fists clenched, now had to clear his throat. "It's good you were able to get here quickly. I have something to show you."

That seemed to further pique Phainon's interest in the exact wrong direction. "Oh?" He set his coffee cup down as he leaned back against the desk, sizing Mydei up with his wandering eyes. With his face all ruddy and pupils blown wider than the Dawn Device, he looked like a man ready to be ravaged. "I'm all ready for you. Show me."

This conversation was clearly doomed from the moment he sent that message earlier. Not that Mydei could exactly blame Phainon for reaching this level of desperation, seeing as how three entire weeks had passed since they last met up. It was just the wrong time and place for any form of intimacy to blossom between them.

And apparently his clever little computer virus agreed, because the instant Phainon leaned back and put pressure on the keyboard, about a hundred different popup windows exploded on the screen with a deafening cacophony of error sound effects. They both startled, Phainon throwing himself forward off the desk as he grabbed his ears in pain. After the initial shock, he looked at Mydei with a completely spooked expression.

"What was that?!"

"That," Mydei began with an exasperated sigh, "was exactly what I tried to warn you about. You were just too busy with your poor attempts at seduction."

"Poor? Come on, Mydei. You can't possibly tell me you weren't at least a *little bit—*"

"Look. It's here."

Mydei pointed back towards the monitor which was no longer flooded with error reports. Instead, what Phainon found waiting for him there was the intense stare of one highly unamused Khaslana surrounded by a condensed wall of red and black visual glitches.

The two blinked at each other wordlessly for a while, Phainon wearing the same expression Mydei had worn the first time he encountered the creature. At least they could share in their less-than-graceful moments together.

“Mydei.”

“Yes?”

“What…is *that?*” Phainon’s voice was also shaky. Had that disturbance really rattled him so badly?

Mydei huffed. “Why are you asking me? It’s your fault this thing showed up.” His tone was assertive, hardened by all that he had experienced with the creature thus far. But Phainon just wore a clueless expression, like he had nothing to do with this situation at all. How irritating.

“Your *Trash King Quest* account. The possessed character sprite must’ve had some kind of virus attached to it. That’s why this,” he pointed at the sprite hovering on the screen, “small elf thing has been stuck on my monitor ever since.”

Khaslana still looked miffed, especially under Phainon’s intense scrutiny. He jabbed a finger at the monitor, as if he could reach through and pluck at the sprite’s feathers. The screen cast a rippling effect where he touched, and only a faint smear remained afterwards. Good thing Mydei had recently purchased a new bottle of screen cleaner. He’d been a lot more tactile since his tiny friend had appeared.

Phainon cast a dubious look in his direction. “Okay. First of all, an elf? Really? Looks more like an angel to me. Secondly, Mydeimos, why did you even message the account to begin with? That’s really risky.”

Of course that was his first concern. Not the fact that his own computer had been contaminated and his personal information was put at risk for over two decades, not at all. He was only worried about Mydei’s wellbeing. Typical.

“Someone had to do something. Better me than the others, anyway.”

“Why do you always have to—”

Khaslana interrupted him with another loud prompt appearing and Phainon winced. While Phainon had flipped the script to start chewing Mydei out

instead (what a hypocrite he was), the creature had finally summoned that twisted sword back to its side and assumed an offensive stance. Mydei wasn't quite sure what exactly it was planning to do to them from the other side of the screen, but at least poor Bubbles had finally been put out of his misery.

Phainon's hands flew to his hips, defiant and ready to hand out a stern warning. Apparently he decided to take an attitude with Mydei today. He nodded sagely, puffing out his chest, "Even your little buddy agrees with me."

"Last time I checked it was *your* problem to begin with, HKS." Mydei wouldn't fall for his provocations. He was stronger than this. He would keep a level head and get to the heart of the matter before Phainon could squirm his way out of a proper conversation. "I've learned a lot about it over the past couple of weeks. Maybe you could shed some light on what led up to all of this."

Realizing that Mydei was serious, Phainon averted his eyes and reached for his previously discarded cup. He took a sip nervously. "I'll try my best. Just don't get your hopes up."

Too late, you're already here in my room and I've got my eyes set on you. Mydei would get the truth from him one way or another.

Phainon's account was about what was expected of him. He fumbled with his words, trying to piece together a sloppy account of every strange anomaly he'd encountered throughout his life, and reached the crux of the matter without much flair: "So that's how it started. My computer was always slow and I *tried* to fix it on my own, but nothing worked. The suspension of my TKQ account wasn't shocking at all. I was just tired of trying only to fail."

"So you decided to ignore the long-standing issue right in front of you and distracted yourself with work instead. How unsurprising." Mydei was not impressed with his little story in the slightest. He shot a withering glare at Phainon, who was still trying his best to be as avoidant as possible, before deciding to just say *screw it* and pulled him in close by the hand.

Their eyes met again and Phainon shuddered with his entire body. Of course he would be just as unnerved as Mydei had been earlier. They may have fallen tragically out of sync recently, but at their core, they were still one and the same.

Mydei ran his thumb over Phainon's rosy knuckles, smoothing out the tension built up beneath the skin. It was nice to feel another person's touch after all these endless days of isolation. Living people weren't as warm as machines, but the softness of human skin, the hitch in his breath and the heat crawling over his cheeks could never be recreated by an inanimate object.

He held Phainon's gaze now, searching. And then Mydei smiled, unarmed for once. "It's just me. Won't you look at me?"

Phainon let out a deep exhale, trembling slightly, "It's *just* you? That's wrong. Don't you know you're everything?"

He sagged into Mydei's side, bending far over to rest in the crook of his neck. Mydei didn't complain even as Phainon gave a few sniffles beside his ear.

A little longer, he told himself as the invisible minutes ticked by. *Let me hold onto you.*

Coming down from that level of tension was slower than Mydei had anticipated, but he couldn't complain when Phainon was finally at his side. He finally broke the silence after an uncertain amount of time had passed by clicking on Khaslana with the mouse. The creature had drifted off again

once the attention had shifted away from the screen, but now it was alive and ready for some coddling. Really, quite similar to Phainon after all.

It made grabby hands and Mydei obliged without complaint. Phainon’s brow wrinkled in confusion, so he supplemented blandly, “It likes the mouse pointer.”

Phainon's face fell a bit at that. “So he does.”

“Why do you sound so bitter?”

“I'm not bitter.” Phainon shifted in place, leaning his cheek closer to Mydei’s. It was like he was also set on eliminating whatever space remained between them and latched on hard. Twiddling with Mydei’s fingers, he muttered darkly, “He probably wants to hold your hand.”

That earned him an incredulous laugh from Mydei. “You're just projecting now.”

“You wish,” he retorted lightly. His voice had grown dull all of a sudden, not a single word uttered with joy. He probably knew what was looming on the horizon now that the two of them were calm enough to talk without horrifically seizing up.

Taking both of his hands now, Mydei gave all his attention without reservation. “You will look at me this time. I won’t let you run away from me anymore.”

“I wasn’t—”

“You were running from all of us. We all saw it. It was only out of respect for your feelings that the others didn’t bother you.” Mydei’s voice remained level no matter how badly he wanted to counter Phainon’s adamant denial with a proper reality check. That kind of confrontation wouldn’t achieve anything but two sore throats and hearts that were even worse for wear. “But I know you better than that. I know that more than anything, you secretly wanted us to want you back.”

Phainon inhaled through his nose, already disconcerted but not yet ready to throw in the towel. His persistence was always a pain. “That’s…not a good explanation.”

“Then I’ll spell it out for you now. You met a roadblock that made you feel like you couldn't be of any use to us anymore. So you ran away to find more people in need of help. You worked yourself to the bone under the guise of saving yourself, but that’s just not true. You never cared about your own wellbeing at all. The only thing on your mind was finding a way to make yourself useful again.”

“That’s…really unfair, Mydeimos,” Phainon mumbled, his face crumpling into a pained grimace.

“I don’t care. Just because you don’t want to hear it doesn’t mean it’s untrue.”

Phainon went quiet for a couple moments. He held his breath carefully, resisting the urge to lash out and say something he might regret. Restraint wasn’t his virtue, but he was too good to hurt the people he loved. That’s why it was so easy for Mydei to push him this far in the first place.

After a few tense beats, he clicked his tongue and spat, “So what if it’s true? I’m allowed to make my own decisions. If I decide that I want to help people and work all the time and run myself into the ground in the process, who’s going to stop me?”

Wasn’t that obvious already? Who else would wait outside for hours to pick Phainon up from his late-night shift at the local salad buffet? Who else would drop everything at a single word to cheer him up on the days where his depressing thoughts threatened to consume him?

Who else would spend the better half of a month looking for a way to restore his gaming account—having to deal with shitty technical support lines, a rogue computer virus that was basically sentient, and horrible customers at work with a conveniently terrible taste in novels—just to bring him back into their life?

It's so obvious to everyone else. So look at me, see how I've already given you my all without you even realizing.

Mydei sighed, "*I* will, you moron."

"You really don't need to concern yourself with me, Mydei. All this stuff about recovering my game account and all the messages and calls and waiting around for me…it's too much."

"So now I'm too much for you? Weren't you the one who just said you were 'all ready' for me? What happened to the brazen Phainon I know so well?" Mydei cocked a defiant eyebrow his way and tried to hold it together when Phainon tried to mask his rapidly intensifying fluster. Oh, he was *so* easy.

He yelped, "That's a different matter altogether! Why are you even bringing that up now?"

"Because you're being ridiculous. Of course I'm going to worry about you, who do you take me for? Implying that I might actually let you go off on your own to die in a ditch is almost insulting. Do you really think that little of me? That little of *yourself?"*

"Sorry. I don't know what's wrong with me." Phainon swallowed uncomfortably, setting his pride away to finally accept Mydei's concern. It took him long enough. "It's been a long month, Mydei. A really, really long month without you."

"I know." He felt it every time his eyes opened in the morning, every time he paced around his cold and stale apartment searching for something that had suddenly disappeared, every single time he closed his eyes and dreamed of the life they were supposed to have built together.

Mydei squeezed his hands tighter. They had grown clammy in the midst of their arguing, but he refused to let go. He pulled Phainon closer, close enough for their noses to brush against one another. Phainon's breath was warm on his cheeks. He badly wanted to kiss him.

Unmasking his concern and blatant affection, he continued, “From now on, you better not forget to rely on me when you’re slipping. We all have our own problems, but it’s always better to face them together. Besides, you’d do the same for me, right?”

Phainon looked to be in a daze. His eyes were narrowed in on Mydei’s slightly-chapped lips, mentally running over each crevice he had long familiarized himself with throughout the years they spent together. He looked like he wanted to devour Mydei, to give him any and everything he wanted without second thought. Their breaths mixed together in an invisible cloud and Phainon gasped out, “Of course I would. I would do anything for you.”

Smugly, Mydei wet his lips and leaned impossibly closer. He was quickly falling into dangerous territory with his taunting. “Always so eager to please.” He just barely grazed his lips against Phainon’s cheek before pulling back again. Then, earnestly, he said, “You have a good heart, Phainon. I would hate to see it broken.”

He seemed to visibly buffer at that sentence. Mydei mentally pat himself on the back for still having the power to leave Phainon flushed and speechless after all these years. At least he’d never have to worry about losing their spark the way couples tended to do after marriage. Their relationship of only a few short years felt like an entire lifetime already, and nothing had changed at all between them.

Phainon stuttered out, “What, I—” He paused abruptly to clear his throat, trying his best to retain some face even after falling flat on it several times. Even with his wide eyes, twitching grin and sweat-streaked hairline, he was still just as attractive and endearing as always in Mydei’s eyes. “Ahem. It won’t be broken though, because…”

He surged forward and gave Mydei his most pathetic, pleading expression. Those bright eyes of his had misted over into a display of pure subservience to his emotions. As much as Phainon was a decent actor, the truth behind his words were evident. This show was as close to a genuine unveiling of his heart as he could manage.

“Because it’s safe in your hands, right?”

And as much as Mydei wanted to tease him for exhibiting such obvious desperation, he wouldn’t. Not when Phainon clearly needed to hear the truth and have all his cruelest doubts firmly dispelled once and for all.

He scoffed, “Do you even have to ask? Your heart is safe with me. Just as it’s been for all the years we’ve been together.”

“Huh.” Phainon froze on the spot, stopping halfway between that pitiful demeanor and genuine surprise. His pupils were still blown wide with that familiar tenderness, but the look on his face was unusual. It was as if he couldn’t believe the words spilling from Mydei’s mouth right then. As bad as he may have been with verbal affirmations, surely it wasn’t *that* shocking to have your partner of five years and counting express their love, right? Mydei could only prod him for an explanation.

“What’s with that expression? You look dumb.”

Phainon swallowed again, then laughed and fell back into his arms. He wasn’t light in the slightest, all muscle after biking everywhere his entire life and regularly exercising with Mydei on their more lucid mornings. But he didn’t mind at all when that weight pressed down into him, even as his sharp elbows dug into Mydei’s side and his knee knocked against his own hard enough to bruise. It had been ages since this clingy dog had smothered him in affection.

Mydei could practically spot his tail wagging as Phainon murmured into his skin, “Nothing. I’m just…happy. I’m always happy to be with you, Mydeimos.”

“Someone’s pent up. Too bad I don’t have the energy to do anything today.”

“Aww.” Despite the whining tone, his words were too lazy to take seriously. Mydei figured he just needed some more time to accept that this unconditional devotion was his to have and keep forever. Mydei would gladly wait and remind him until he knew that it was real—that *they* were real.

In the past, we only ever understood one another through our bodies. Now, though, I think words suit us better.

He pressed another kiss to Phainon's temple and just held him as if they would never be parted again.

"...By the way, don't think I forgot about you casually glossing over the fact that you quit your job."

"Later, Mydei. I promise to tell you everything. Just…" Phainon sank deeper into his arms. His love was like a warm blanket against the cold current flowing through the rest of the apartment. Mydei gladly absorbed everything he was willing to give. "Let me have this for now."

As they were busy being wrapped up in one another's embrace, neither noticed the dim silhouette of Khaslana projected on the monitor behind them. The angelic creature was clutching to the mouse's hand like a lifeline as it endured an onslaught of burning, glitchy waves. No matter how brutal it got, it would continue to resist. It *had* to.

Even if it was doomed to become nothing but coded lines of digital ash in the end, it would see this through to the end. That was the only way it had ever known.

Chapter 6: Broken Wings

“Sleeping in past your alarm? That’s not like you at all.”

Mydei tried his best to ignore the finger poking into his cheek. He stubbornly burrowed his head further into the plush surface beneath, seeking out the lulling warmth of rest once more.

The ‘pillow’ he was laid out on laughed, its plush form jolting slightly with the stuttered motion as Mydei felt the hand shift to his head. It smoothed out his unruly mane, stroking over his scalp in a way that nearly made him preen with affection. “Oh, you like that?” That voice was all too sultry for the early hours of the morning, rolling off a smooth tongue like it was second nature.

Mydei growled out groggily, “Pillows can’t talk. Shut up or I’ll smother you.”

Another laugh. “I think you already are.” Being built like a warrior from ancient times meant that Mydei was also incredibly heavy. Even someone with Phainon’s build would feel uncomfortable under his weight. But no matter how his arms and thighs numbed each time he stayed over, Phainon never shoved him off. He probably enjoyed being crushed by Mydei’s body, anyway. “As nice as this is, you’re still running on a schedule. It’s time to wake up, my dear Mydeimos.”

Well. That was one way to rouse someone. Mydei fluttered open a single golden eye. He could just barely make out Phainon’s troublesome grin in the scant light cast from his window. Perhaps it was time to invest in more efficient curtains.

“You’re still here.”

Phainon kept at his gentle prodding, starting to pull on his hair for attention and grope at whatever body part he could lay hands on; Mydei’s biceps, pectorals, and thighs were all at his disposal. This part was all too familiar;

Phainon always considered himself a ‘tactile’ learner when it came to relics, wanting to feel the entire weight of history with no holds barred. He’d cup both hands around the circumference of a dusty pithos, running his long fingers over the rim with a coy glint to his eye as he mouthed one senseless thing or another in Mydei's direction. Naturally, little ever got done when they paired up.

He scoffed, tugging at Mydei’s ear now. “Of course I am. You trapped me underneath you sometime last night and I’ve been stuck here ever since!”

“So?”

“You have to work! Think of your poor, helpless employees, Mydei. They need you.” Phainon’s eyes shone with false tears. He still managed the audacity to brush against Mydei’s nipple though, stroking over his bare skin like a man subtly dying of thirst. He pulled back quickly enough though, keeping his actions teasing. “Think of Uncle Krateros. The old man can’t even download files without your guidance. He must be so lost on his own.”

“You’re the last person who should be commenting on someone else’s tech skills.”

“Now that’s just rude. I’ll have you know that I’m perfectly capable with computers now.” He gave a self-satisfied smirk. “I’ve even restored my laptop to perfect working condition. Now you’re the one lagging behind, Mydei.”

Mydei was already used to lagging behind these days, but whatever. That was the least of his concerns at the moment. “You mean, your computer’s working again?”

“Yup. It’s been running smoothly ever since… about two weeks ago. Not just that, but the World Wound Web works even faster than before!” He sounded incredibly proud of himself, like he had solved the issue all on his own instead of being overwhelmed by his own inability to handle the situation. Mydei sincerely doubted Phainon understood the implications of his words.

Nevermind the fact that Mydei had been fighting a nonexistent battle for the better half of a month—that the virus had been purged and access to the gaming account had been restored not by his own efforts—none of that mattered anyway.

Two weeks had passed since his computer was restored to working order.

Two weeks had also passed since Khaslana manifested and infected Mydei's computer.

Drawing a conclusion about virus transferal was not difficult at all. So it was a singular entity that passed between gaming accounts and left no residual traces on the source? Unusual, but then again, everything about this situation already was. Whatever its programmed "desire" was, it seemed to fulfill it wholeheartedly.

Though, it was hard to believe that just turning off the computer and choosing natural selection was enough to restore Phainon's laptop to a pristine condition after twenty years of wear and tear. Had its performance been so terrible all this time with the memory card stuffed to the brim with Khaslana's weird glitches? How did he even get anything done like that?

Just another instance of Phainon thinking something detrimental to his wellbeing was actually normal and he just handled it worse than other people. The man was far more resilient than anyone gave him credit for.

In the midst of drawing his own conclusions, a teleslate screen was shoved into Mydei's face. The time read 8:15 AM. Still early enough to get a workout in, if he moved quick enough.

Phainon, already accustomed to his desire for routine, pinned Mydei in place. He really could have an iron grip when he was desperate. "Nuh-uh, no running today. We're eating breakfast together!"

"But—"

"Honeycakes. Can't. Go. On. Without. Them." *Titans*, he was being a pain today.

“Spoiled.” Still, it was the least Mydei could do after suffocating him all night. Nevermind the fact that Phainon could cook just as well—if he insisted on having Mydei’s specialty honeycakes for breakfast, then he’d get just that.

He cupped a hand around Phainon’s cheek and placed a fleeting kiss there. Even with morning breath and unkempt hair flying in every direction, the man was too charming to resist. His skin flushed at once, from his collarbones to his ears, and once his arms fell slack, Mydei took the chance to roll off his chest. “Wait, Mydei…”

“You wanted this. Now get up.”

He ignored Phainon’s sputtered complaints, all too happy to leave the man tripping over himself once again. A little torture never killed anyone.

After weeks of eating whatever was within reach or opting for overpriced takeout, it was really good to finally cook again. This was also the most well-rested Mydei felt in ages, not even a hint of drowsiness remaining. Each step he took across the kitchen tiles was pleasantly temperate on his bare feet. He scrubbed his hands clean, slipped on his red chimera-embroidered apron (courtesy of Castorice) and tied his hair back before getting to work.

Flour. Sugar. Milk. Eggs. Vanilla. Honey—lots of honey. His recipe veered on the sweeter side due to personal preference. Phainon, in comparison, rarely felt cravings for anything beyond his typical healthy diet of glorified leaves and grass. His “cheat day” requests were usually limited to salted or fried meat and vegetable dishes from his hometown. But here he was, surprising Mydei time and again.

He had just finished stirring everything together in the bowl and began to heat the pan when those same strong arms from before wrapped around his torso. “Phainon,” he acknowledged briefly before returning to his craft. The other man just groaned and folded deeper into Mydei’s back, deliberately

avoiding the sore spot in the middle that always ached after a long day of work.

How gentle he was, often caressing that lopsided birthmark in the same spot while they laid together. Phainon would mouth over it, just light enough to leave prickling bumps upon the skin, and mumble, “Each mark of your pain will be remembered.” A tad dramatic for moderate soreness, but undeniably heartfelt.

Now, though…

“You’ve gotten slower in the kitchen lately. Feeling your age, Mydeimos?”

So he’s back to being a thorn in my side, Mydei mentally sighed. He dropped the whisk into the bowl before he instinctively began brandishing it as a weapon to ward off stray pests from his sacred kitchen. Now on the defensive, he crossed his arms and huffed. “You’re the one who’s feeling their age. That’s the only explanation for your recent midlife crisis.”

Apparently his accumulated list of ways to torment Phainon had reached its apex already, because a pair of sharp canines instantly dug into Mydei’s neck like he was seeking blood. He yelped, reaching for the first object in the vicinity, and ended up whacking Phainon like a fly with the batter-coated whisk. It hit him violently in the head, causing him to finally unlatch from Mydei’s nape, and both men groaned in unison. After a moment of staggering, they locked eyes and took the offensive, shoving one another around the edge of a heated stove as globs of their breakfast flew through the air.

“You’re such a dog!”

“And you’re a brutish cat! My forehead’s going to bruise!”

The insults went flying between them too, adding to the growing puddle of filth around them. It was only a short while into their roughhousing, however, that Phainon unexpectedly slipped and instantly took Mydei down with him.

They ended up just as they had been positioned before—Mydei sprawled out on top of Phainon, who had willingly taken the brunt of the fall and wheezed out a little as his back hit the floor.

“Fool. You should’ve turned away instead of letting me crush you to death,” Mydei chided, smoothing out Phainon’s pinched brow.

The other man just laughed. “Ha, no way. Even if I die, my chivalry will outlive me.” Complete nonsense coming from a sleep-rumpled fool covered in raw batter, but his impassioned rhetoric alone was almost convincing. They basked in the sticky atmosphere for a moment, just feeling one another, before Phainon relaxed into Mydei’s hold.

“I really missed this.”

There they were, wearing their breakfast and sweating on the dirty kitchen tiles like a pair of idiots after an impromptu wrestling session. The pan was still searing nearby and the scent of burning oil was almost acrid. This was hardly the picture of a romantic morning.

Somehow though, it fit them just fine.

Soon enough, Mydei sat up with a sneer and brushed himself off. It did nothing to cleanse him of the flour clumping in his hair. “I didn’t. My kitchen has been spotless without you throwing all your dishes everywhere.”

“Or, it’s spotless because you didn’t cook the entire time I was gone.”

Mydei just clicked his tongue, not honoring that provocation with a response. So what if it was true? He’d never admit to it.

Phainon, though, was never one to let these things slide. He always bit down hard, too stubborn and too attention-seeking to release him until he got his way. “Hit a nerve, Mydeimos?”

“I was just distracted by the batter all over your face. It’s a good look on you.”

Their banter continued where it had last left off weeks and weeks ago, as if it had just been stuck on pause the whole time, waiting for them to come back and find their peace with one another. Such was the foundation of their relationship, the way they originally found common ground after months of stagnation once they learned to relate to one another through their physicality. It wasn't limited to intimate moments either, but shifted over to aggressive competitions when their youthful rage caught up to them.

There was that time in Mydei's fourth year when he was interning at the university library and Phainon dragged him into a ridiculous book-stacking contest that quickly spiraled out of control and almost lost him the job. At the thirty-third book, Phainon's stack began to sway precariously in either direction, eventually ramming into Mydei's and sending everything tumbling down to the floor with a loud *THUD!* The sound was so great a few students in the outer hall complained, leading the head librarian to come chew them out.

Mydei, humiliated, kept his eyes steadily on the ground as he groveled before his boss. Kind as the elderly Zenotus was, he could not stand for the blatant disrespect of his books, and thus he ordered Mydei to clean and reshelve every outstanding volume from that week on his own. The task was so tall he had to stay hours past closing each night to make a dent in his workload.

Of course, Phainon ended up sneaking in after hours to help. And they only ended up making out in the corner like, two times at maximum. They could be productive when they needed to.

In truth, they'd always been just this stupid around one another since the beginning. And no matter how bleak the situation looked, there was the unspoken promise that it would *always* remain this way.

Mydei never thought softness suited him well. He was too big, too gruff, too Kremnoan for the delicate sensibilities of the Okhemans. Not exactly the perfect image of a gentle lover in their eyes.

Still, he whispered, "I missed you, too." And their morning continued as usual.

After remaking the batter, sitting down with a stack of honeycakes each, scrubbing his body clean of every speck of wasted food, and pulling on a cardigan and slacks—Mydei was finally ready to leave the house at just after nine-thirty. He set one of his carrying cases down in the kitchen while combing his hair back, walking back and forth between the bathroom and open areas of the apartment in search of all his belongings.

He heard Phainon pacing at one point, but he seemed to calm down after a while and took to waiting patiently for Mydei in the sitting room; said patience which seemed to disappear as soon as he laid eyes on the man and shot up from his seat like one of Tribbie's toy rockets.

"Mydei," he called, "Are you proud of me? I called Cyrene and Castorice, and I also messaged Hyacine and Cipher privately."

It was too early to be proud of him for doing the bare minimum to communicate with his friends of over seven years. All of the girls had known Phainon far longer than Mydei had, and he wasn't the only one missing him. "And how did that go?"

Phainon gripped his teleslate in both hands like a lifeline. "Well…I'm still breathing?"

"That's probably more than you deserve." Mydei busied himself with his sleeve buttons, ignoring whatever wounded look Phainon cast his way. "Cyrene's family to you. It's wrong to cut your family out like that."

That comment earned him a cough in return. He raised a brow and met Phainon's gradually-reddening face. Another cough, a shifty glance, and

then Phainon’s wobbling voice—“Technically that also applies to you. Since we’re, you know.”

“Since we’re *what?*”

“Don’t make me say it!”

Mydei was in the middle of a definitely-suave, not at all humiliating line when he got a closer look at Phainon’s teleslate. His jaw clamped down immediately, eyes narrowed as the latest search results were displayed for all to see:

> does he actually like me or am i delusional

> gladiatr

> should i quit my job

> wovenin upload résumé

> how to nonchalantly seduce someone help please

Forget the “family” talk, Mydei had more pressing matters to attend to. “Why did you search for ‘gladiatr?’”

Phainon didn’t honor him with a response. Not surprising at all. Mydei’s mood continued to sour as he cast a highly judgmental stare his partner’s way.

“You have the wrong idea. It wasn't anything serious!” Phainon floundered for the right words, and inevitably said all the wrong ones instead.

Mydei, being a rational person, came to understand him rather quickly. But he couldn’t resist the urge to hit Phainon with a few more jabs before their morning together ended. “Hm? So you're willing to leave all *this,*” he gestured vaguely at the room around him, and then at the leftover stack of

honeycakes set out on the counter, which earned him a whimper, “behind for a casual fling?”

He then turned and headed towards the front door, paying no heed to Phainon’s brainless attempts at fighting back. Mydei pulled on his coat, secured his usual satchel over his shoulders and reached for the doorknob just slowly enough for Phainon to come barreling into him once more from the side.

Round, pleading eyes burned a hole right into his profile. “Where are you going?”

And Mydei just couldn’t resist messing with him one final time. He hid his smile and swiveled back to face Phainon head-on, crossing his arms and assuming a bland expression. *Perfect.*

“To work. To pay the bills and afford all these nice ingredients to make dinner for my ungrateful, disloyal husband.”

Phainon immediately choked on whatever he was going to say next. He looked ready to explode with how intensely red his face was, and all he did was echo *“HUSBAND?”* before gaping like a fish out of water. How satisfying to leave him in such a state at the end of all the suffering Mydei had endured. Revenge was easy when your partner was just so easy.

Mydei left the apartment then, only pausing briefly by the elevator as he remembered to call out to the wide open door, “Have fun at your little rendezvous. At the end of the day, you'll still be here begging for me anyway.”

He was happy to leave it there, firmly securing a victory for himself amid an endless tally of losses. But once again, Phainon would continue to surprise him.

“Wait! Don’t leave just yet, I still have to—” He rounded the corner with purpose and stood before Mydei, only an imperceptible bit taller. So his pace was undoubtedly faster now, catching up after hardly any time at all. That was new.

What was a self-assured win fizzled into utter nothingness as Phainon held his cheek and leaned in for a honey-sweet kiss, saccharine enough to make Mydei's heart flutter against his own will. *Damn it. Damn it all to Thanatos' realm.*

"Have a good day, Mydei."

His tone was gentle and obviously a little proud of himself. Mydei, again at a loss for words, nodded once and backed into the elevator like a lovestruck fool. And he hardly uttered a single word the rest of the morning.

At least his productivity was up, having his life balance restored to acceptable levels of rest, relaxation and companionship. Apparently he was basically glowing like a lamp the entire day, so much so that even Krateros muttered not so far behind his back, "I see that ridiculous boy of yours finally came to his senses."

If Phainon had come to his senses then Mydei had clearly lost all of his in the process. Wasn't that something Professor Anaxagoras taught them back in their student days—that "equivalent exchange" he coveted so greatly? Right, that was it. The concept seemed to apply to all areas of Mydei's life constantly; *exchange your homeland for opportunity,* or *your honor for social acceptance.* That's how it usually was, anyway. The costs were steep, but never too detrimental, given that he benefitted from every outcome.

Now it was a little different. Be it *your computer for Phainon's* or *sleep for the pursuit of truth* or even *that novel you really needed to return in exchange for a failed opportunity to one-up your partner,* he just couldn't seem to win even once.

That trend stretched further into the day as the Parting Hour brought Mydei back to the familiar beige of his apartment building. It was a more attractive sight overall when compared to Phainon's dingy little place, but the lack of color was too far of a lean in the minimalist direction for Mydei's tastes. He never did like the gray haze that settled over Kremnos' industrial scene growing up.

The slight chill in the west wind was finally shrugged off along with his overcoat at the front door. His boots and satchel followed, and a minute later, Mydei was treading through the silent expanse of his home exactly as he had each day over the past month. The difference was nearly indiscernible now, save for a few key details: a half-filled coffee cup on the coffee table, the same plate of sad-looking honeycakes sitting atop the counter, and a leather book left wide open on the dining table.

Disconcerting. That was all Mydei could think before a clamor came from the office. The door was closed shut, but the noises coming from within were still very audible from the entryway. It sounded like a hard object slamming down onto the desk, followed by the rapid clicking of a keyboard and the sharp hum of electricity. What was Phainon up to now? Still trying to get that résumé uploaded? It shouldn't be too much of a problem if his laptop was running faster.

Mydei pushed the door open with a slight *creak,* letting in the light cast from the hall into the dim room. There Phainon was, seated at the desktop computer where Khaslana was hovering in place as always, his hand gripped around the mouse like a weapon. Mydei couldn't make out his expression from the door, but his pale hair seemed to glow from behind. How could a person be so naturally beautiful amidst so much building frustration and anger in their life?

The creature seemed to recognize Mydei's footsteps before Phainon did, and its gaze shifted away from the office chair to the intruder. Somehow, despite wearing the same blank expression as ever, it seemed agitated.

"Are you harassing one another now?" Mydei hoped to break the tense air with some easy banter, but it fell flat upon drawing close enough to make out Phainon's terse glare. Were they really fighting with each other? How did that even work?

Now hoping to de-escalate the situation, Mydei forcibly removed the mouse from Phainon's grasp and placed the nearby glass of water in it instead. "Drink it properly instead of slamming it around," he ordered. Phainon, probably too far gone to argue, began to sip from the glass. In the meantime, Mydei navigated over to Khaslana's trembling form and let it

hold onto the mouse for emotional support. Once it had calmed down, Mydei decided to probe it for context.

“Khaslana,” he said, “can you—”

CRASH!

Glass shattered all over the floor as the remaining water soaked through the rug and their socks. The sound startled Mydei, but Phainon was frozen in place, his face gaunt and hand still shaking around a nonexistent cup. Concerned, Mydei reached out to check for injuries, but he jerked away instantly like a cornered animal.

“What…did you say?”

Mydei hadn’t said much of anything with how quickly he was interrupted, but something in there had clearly set Phainon off. He finished his sentence, “‘Khaslana, can you talk to me?’”

Phainon took a shuddering breath. “And who…are you talking to?”

“The fairy creature. It answers to that name.” He watched Phainon carefully, taking in each rigid pull of his muscles, the way his darkened eyes seemed to blink in and out of focus, the sweat pooling on his hairline and how utterly *terrified* he looked. It wasn’t just shell-shock from the glass breaking, no. That reaction was undeniable—the name meant something to him too.

Mydei spoke again, “Where have you heard the name ‘Khaslana’ before?”

“Nowhere.” A clipped, one-word response that was so obviously ingenuine, Mydei barely resisted the urge to reach forward and throttle him.

“That was a quick answer.”

“Just drop it, Mydei.”

How stubborn. Good thing Mydei could be just as bullheaded when it mattered most. He decided to try a new angle of attack next. “That book

was left open on the table."

Phainon was all too happy to embrace the sudden shift in topic. With a deceptively light tone, he asked, "What book?"

"The 500 year old artifact from the special collections at work. The one that has to be kept in a protective casing at all times."

Phainon nodded sagely. "Ah. That one." He wasn't even denying his own oversight now. *So out of character.*

Unimpressed, Mydei continued to implicate him, "You know proper handling procedures better than anyone. Something must have shaken you pretty badly for you to abandon an artifact like that."

"Your friend…" Phainon's breath was pulled taut with thinly-veiled distress. "'Khaslana,' he was acting strange. That's all."

You're a poor liar, Phainon, Mydei thought to himself before voicing aloud. He really, truly was. But given his clear misery, he was in far worse shape than he had been the day before. And Mydei was willing to give him more time to come to terms with his issues. As long as they had each other, everything would work out in the end.

Right on cue, Phainon began deflecting again. "I don't know what you're talking about. Come on, let's not do this now. No one wants to argue after working all day, right?" He pulled Mydei over the pile of broken glass shards underfoot and began leading him down the hallway. "I think it's about time for our evening bath!"

What else could Mydei do but let himself be whisked away?

This abnormal routine continued throughout the week. Phainon seemed reluctant to go home, to part with Mydei at all, but he was just as eager to shoo the man off to work every morning. Each one of his messes had been promptly cleaned up and he was clearly determined to be as unobtrusive as

possible. Mydei didn’t catch him unawares in the office room again, but there was no doubt Phainon was still hiding himself away in the darkened room during the day. At least the creature didn’t appear as perturbed compared to the first time they clashed.

On one occasion, Mydei found Phainon sprawled out on the sitting room divan reading *Origin of Primordial Chaos.* His long legs were a sight to behold even beneath those hideous purple lounge pants he was so enamored with. Mydei laid a hand upon his thigh, causing Phainon to glance up curiously from his book.

“And here I thought all you read was the monthly edition of *Moneymaking for Dummies,”* Mydei taunted. He sat beside Phainon and leaned in to check the current page number—forty-nine. It was a relatively short story, but he’d barely made it a fourth of the way through. Seems it really wasn’t to his tastes. “What’s the verdict then?”

Phainon grimaced. “I don't typically read stories of this kind.”

“Trust me, no one else does either.” The ill-tempered scholar from before was a testament to that. It was for the best that the archival team resolved that request before a repeat incident occurred.

“Ha, perhaps. But don't you agree that the text offers unexpected insight into the past?”

“In the footnotes and citations?”

“In general. Though the execution is questionable, there is merit to his theorems.” Phainon set the book down atop his chest and faced the ceiling as if searching for something beyond anyone’s perception. “Little is known about the chrysos heirs of the prophecy. That shouldn't be though, since they were all local celebrities and several were already legends carved into the history books.”

Mydei knew exactly what he was getting at. Among all of Amphoreus’ historians, it was the Flame-Chase fanatics who were most often left unsatisfied by their research results. How could it be that the revered heroes

of ancient times were also so neglected by the countless slates, scrolls and doliums alike? How was it that not a single name survived from that era? Surely the people of those times were not so careless as to leave their greatest heroes and deities unnamed, right?

Even the power of their combined contemplation could not remedy this problem plaguing the entire world. Sure, they could make an effort—perhaps history was destroyed intentionally by malicious forces like the Cleaners, or followers of the Enigmata were involved somehow. It never amounted to much in the end aside from twin headaches and a disdain for the author's cryptic thinking.

"I mean, *Khaos?"* Phainon's brow twitched with some indescribable force of emotion. "This Kryptos is a total lunatic. The obvious Kephale fetish aside, he's all show and no substance with these naming conventions!"

Mydei snorted lightly, "It's a name found throughout Amphoreus' history."

"Then why have I never heard it before? Must not be that important."

"It's important to anyone with a brain, you amateur historian." Mydei whacked him over the head with a notepad shared during their ruminating. "It's high time you caught up on your studies."

Thursday in particular was another deviation from the expected, though not because of any great fault on Phainon's behalf. He was surprisingly active that evening when Mydei found him back at the computer messing around with Khaslana.

The man was usually tidy, but the crumbs and wrinkled food wrappers before him told a different story. He was engrossed in a bizarre, disorganized series of web searches, spanning anywhere from *salad eating contests* to *sky castrum mural fragments* to *best penaconian films where the dog lives.* Clearly the prompts themselves were arbitrary and it was the top pages themselves he cared about. Mydei watched in utter silence for minutes on end as Phainon continuously scrolled through hundreds of webpages just to allow tracking permissions from each and every one.

After a certain point he pushed off from the wall and drew nearer. “What are you doing to my computer now?”

“Mydei!” Phainon cheered with far too much glee. Were those crumbs around his mouth too…? What was he, a toddler? The very grown man in front of him pointed at the pop-up prompt on the screen, exclaiming, “I’m feeding Khaslana cookies!”

Mydei pinched his nose. *There’s no way…*

“That’s not—” Mydei cut himself off as he caught a glimpse of the smirk playing at his partner’s lips. Oh, he knew *exactly* what he was doing. The unkempt scene around him suddenly made a lot more sense. Crumbs and wrappers everywhere? He was causing a scene on purpose. “You really enjoy messing with people.”

In a leering voice, Phainon replied,“Hm? What gave it away?”

“The fact that you're also eating cookies right in front of Khaslana to taunt him. The same way you hold my hand while he just gets the mouse.”

Phainon’s haughty laugh soon followed along with the crumpling of another emptied treat bag. What a way to make the most of his cheat day. “Khaslana's just a string of code simulating life. So I'm giving him some enrichment time to boost his performance capabilities. I'm sure he won't mind too much.” Then, with a scornful grin directed at the screen, he added, “Or you can just think of this as payback for all the havoc you wreaked my entire life. I lost a lot thanks to you, you no-good troublemaker.”

It was true enough, but the act was a bit much. Surely there were better things to do around the apartment than wasting his time torturing a character sprite.

“I didn’t think your relationship had grown so hostile. Are you that full of hatred, Phainon?” he voiced.

“I never said I hated him! I actually like to think Khaslana is very misunderstood.” He seemed to have second thoughts immediately after the

words of praise left his mouth. “Except for when he skewered Bubbles. That's an unforgivable sin!”

At least he still had some common sense. And there was promise for their relationship to improve now that Phainon had evolved from acts of pure malice to petty taunting. Khaslana was also reacting less as the days went by. It must have been a good sign, like the light at the end of a long tunnel.

Friday saw the reunion of their art history group at the Golden Scapegoat Café. Aglaea and Castorice were already sipping from their mugs of herbal tea by the time Mydei and Phainon arrived, wearing a pair of pleased smiles as their more estranged friends approached hand in hand. Tribbie and her sisters, who had yet to outgrow their youthful energy, were excitedly whispering about their extra-special new concoction, “Rainbow Pegasus Bubble Tea.” Hyacine would probably get a kick out of that one.

“Mydeimos, Phainon. It’s nice to see you at this early hour,” Aglaea greeted warmly. Her words clearly held some kind of passive-aggressive sleight within them, but no one could manage a frown on such a beautiful morning. The Month of Cultivation always brought a pleasant heat to Okhema’s maze-like streets, pushing away the lingering wisps of winter to embrace the season of flowers.

Castorice reserved her words and instead held out her hands over the table to each of them, seeking the comfort of their companionship. The trio shared a private smile together before their young friends came bounding over with drinks in tow.

“Snowy! De! You’re back!” The three sisters chimed in unison. Trianne and Trinnon handed over Phainon’s usual coffee order along with Mydei’s juice before heading off on their own. Tribbie sat at the end of the table drinking her own beverage through a yellow, star-shaped bendy straw.

Phainon grinned, tilting his head in a way that caused his springy strands of hair to bounce atop his head. “It’s great to finally see you all again.” No matter how much trouble he’d caused before, that energy was impossible to resist. Everyone collectively relaxed into their seats and let the tension of the previous month wash from their bodies.

The group talked about this and that, conversing about whatever came to mind as memories from years past came rushing in.

“We were in Professor Anaxa’s class together, but while you and Phainon grew closer, I was too shy to introduce myself. Now, I can’t imagine a life where the two of us never became friends.”

“It was our first field trip to Mnestia’s Temple, remember? Agy was so focused on the tour that she didn’t even realize her students had gone missing!”

“Aglaea had a stern gaze, and Tribbie and Castorice were always working on handicrafts in the corner. Even someone like me would feel a little intimidated when I was just starting out!”

“Mydeimos makes a splendid array of fruit tarts. While his unique historical perspectives were certainly a breath of fresh air, it was his talent in the kitchen that first captivated me.”

It was all too easy to fall back into an easy rhythm amongst themselves. After an hour of chatting, Mydei felt astonishingly refreshed.

Continuing from Aglaea’s last point, Phainon nodded excitedly and added, “That reminds me of the time we had a grand feast all together!”

A curious turn in the conversation for sure. Mydei silently racked his brain for any memories relating to feasts. Were communal celebrations counted in

that? The group had always attended the Month of Joy's fish festival to support Mydei's volunteer work at the dining stalls. There was also the Kremnoan Cultural Center's open house day in the Month of Strife where he made every traditional dish preserved in the ancient recipe books.

Tribbie also seemed to follow his thought process. "Oh, for the Month of Gate's homecoming rites? De's pancakes are always the best!"

"No, when we all gathered at the bathhouse for that banquet." At everyone's lasting silence, he redirected in Mydei's direction and gestured wildly, stressing, "You know which one I'm talking about, right Mydei? We had that grape throwing competition and you launched one so hard it shattered Professor Anaxa's glass?"

Phainon's insistence on pushing this topic was honestly puzzling. What was he getting at here? Mydei squinted down at the table, scanning over stray pastry crumbs and coffee stains burned into the wood in hopes of recalling something of value. *Feast, bathhouse, grapes.…*

"You made that gorgeous cake, the one with the gold laurels on it?"

Now his voice was straining with something like desperation. Mydei, ever the determined man, was so focused on remembering that he had almost completely disconnected from reality. He eventually caught hold of one lead, leaving just one word on the tip of his tongue: …*Cake?*

Strangely, something did come to mind: a rich fig cake dressed in a flawless mirror glaze that reflected every star beyond the sky. It was indeed beautiful, and crowned with edible golden leaves made of lemon wafers. Subtle notes of jam, citrus and vanilla filled Mydei's senses, just as vibrant as the day he'd baked it.

When he snapped back into reality, the group was watching his expectantly, Phainon most of all. It wouldn't be polite to keep them waiting, he thought to himself, and then finally answered, "Right. It was something for Mnestia. You stayed in the hot baths too long and turned the color of raw dromas meat."

Phainon perked up at that. He nodded repeatedly, eager for acknowledgement, before his brows furrowed and a scowl replaced his smile. “Hey, if I recall correctly you were the one who pushed me—”

As if sensing an inevitable battle of words to follow, Aglaea swiftly interjected with her usual grace, “Ahem. If I may…”

Her all-seeing eyes shone warily behind the lip of her mug. It was a stance of authority, a promise to correct the unseemly flaws in her students’ work. Mydei was all too familiar with this scenario, and he listened closely, chin lowered out of habit, for the obligatory admonishment regarding their childish behavior.

“Perhaps you are both misremembering. No such feast was ever held between us.”

What?

Tribbie also piped up, her big eyes stretched wider than Amphoreus’ twin moons, “That’s right! We’ve never even been to the bathhouse together!”

“Huh?” Phainon wore the look of a man completely dumbfounded. Mydei may well have laughed if he wasn’t frozen in the exact same position.

Always the gentle mediator, Castorice was quick to supplement an explanation. “Tribbie and her sisters are still young, and in the past they couldn’t enter the hot baths at all. We’ve only held parties where everyone can be included…” She wore a pensive expression as she tore through her own memories for any small inkling of truth. It seemed to come to her soon enough, and she readily suggested, “The last time we celebrated together was during the new year. Surely you’re confusing that occasion with another…?”

A less-than-elegant chortle resounded for a split second. Aglaea always was a woman of mysterious duality. She leaned backwards, satisfied with Castorice’s words, and closed her eyes.

“Might I suggest you two spend less time entertaining your drinks next time so you retain some memory of the evening?” Her snippy tone was undoubtedly grating on the ears of such a people-pleasing crowd. Even Castorice, who had received praise for her careful speculation, winced away from the face of this conflict.

For as much as Mydei respected her judgment, he wasn’t one to shy in the face of adversity. Being a man of Kremnos meant pursuing the core principles of courage, honor, tenacity, sacrifice and reason to the bitter end —even at the cost of his pride. Not that anything could be more shameful than allowing falsehoods to corrupt history.

Amphoreans of all kinds, from every hidden corner of this forsaken world, had nothing but scraps of a plundered past to rely on. Mydei would always strive to ensure that memories remained firmly under his protection.

The argument formed like needles on his tongue, “I never—”

And was unceremoniously quashed the next second by a harsh stamp of a heel on his toes. Mydei hissed back a curse and glared over at his troublemaking partner, who seemed very inclined to ignore his existence. With a jovial chuckle, Phainon agreed, “Understood. We will definitely be more careful next time!”

Mydei shot him a menacing side glance in return. *What are you doing?* It was pretty common knowledge that neither of them were big on drinking. Mydei disliked the astringent taste of alcohol and very rarely indulged during the occasional birthday celebration or rites of Phagousa. Someone with Phainon’s iron will to keep up appearances also wouldn’t slacken so easily. It was almost insulting to suggest that they could act with such indulgence while hosting a public event.

And moreover, Mydei remembered that feast well. Sure, the actual occasion may have been lost on him, but it definitely happened at one point or another within the past half-decade. There was an expertly-crafted cake, sweetened grapes and pomegranate fresh in his mouth, the swirling steam of the hot baths, a sultry whisper smoldering in his ear, *“Mydeimos, your*

body is so unfair," and the sound of a body being shoved hard into the water.

It was something out of a dream, but too real to discount. Becoming too inebriated to recall the details of a party and completely making up the rest was out of the question. But his impassioned disagreement fell to silence in the face of Phainon's discreet headshake. It told Mydei enough to rein him back in—*Not now. Later.*

Phainon waved off the attention with his natural charm, ceding to Tribbie's building anticipation of the summer festivities. The conversation slowly waned as Aglaea, Castorice and Mydei watched on without a word, and a shared glance with Phainon pushed him to finally stand and drag the other man home.

The pair had opted to walk to the café that morning, hoping to bask in the pleasant weather as they met their daily cardio quota, so Mydei took off down the street with Phainon gripping tight to his bicep. The mood was light enough, not yet dampened by that inexplicable dip in the conversation earlier. But Phainon was looking somewhat worse for wear now that his mask was starting to slip again.

His face was slightly pale, resembling the ivory walls between the temple and street more than his bright complexion. If he was coming down with something, Mydei would be sure to take care of him the same way Phainon always cared for him—with unpalatable cough syrup, a cool rag, and a mountain of facial tissues.

"You alright?"

Phainon hugged his side, a shadow partially obscuring his face from view. He seemed in good enough spirits, just…a little distant. Like his mind was wandering the stars as his body remained firmly within reach. "I'm fine. Really, just having you by my side is more than enough."

Mydei leaned close to ruffle his hair, earning himself a gasp of false outrage. When he pulled back, Phainon's cloud of white hair was sticking

up in every direction. It reminded him somewhat of Khaslana's unruly mop. The uncanny parallels between those two just never ceased.

"You've been laying it on thick all week. Are you still not satisfied with the attention you're getting?"

Phainon hummed and knocked his very unbruised forehead—no, the whisk was never going to leave a dent when he was the one constantly ramming into things on his own—against Mydei's. "Looks like I just can't get enough of you, Mydeimos. Would you keep indulging me?

Of course he would. Wasn't that the entire point?

"Could you get my pullover while you're in there? The black one? Thanks."

Phainon's voice drifted into the bedroom from his perch over in the office. Mydei, who was already rummaging around through the cabinets searching for fever reducers, easily complied. Phainon was already looking a little clammy after the journey home and was obviously in need of assistance. Mydei didn't even know he owned a black pullover, but whatever. It was a fair deal for the rancid medicine he'd soon be force-feeding the man.

He pored through his closet (their wardrobes were distinct, but intertwined nonetheless), sifting through each hanger and pile of folded clothes searching for the requested article. *White button-downs, gray sweats, fuzzy animal pajamas…* Phainon had enough junk piled in there to comfortably live off without ever returning to his own apartment. Mydei let out a satisfied noise as finally dug up the tattered hoodie from the very back of

his storage shelves. It might've smelled a little like dust and years of neglect, but it was strangely familiar all the same.

He called out, "Found it. Do you want me to—?!"

What interrupted him this time was a blaring alarm sound so excruciatingly loud Mydei recoiled from the opposite side of the hallway. It had to be an error alert emanating from the computer, from something that set the little virus off. He was more concerned about whether Phainon's hearing was still intact after enduring that kind of shock, since he had reacted so poorly in the past.

Mydei entered the office and his eyes immediately flew to Phainon's distressed figure hunched over in front of the screen. The room was so bright, flooded with flickering light cast from what could only be Khaslana, and stifling enough to fill his lungs with distressing heat. It was the same scorching haze the creature emitted the first and only time Mydei had attempted to forcibly shut it down. The computer's fans were set to an impossible speed, adding an extra layer of noise atop the continuous error windows popping up.

Phainon wasn't covering his ears this time, though; instead, he was gripping the mouse with incredible force as sweat poured down his face. He was incredibly pale, blanched by the increasing strain upon his body. Once Mydei reached him, he made out the man's pinched expression—completely concentrated in enduring whatever pain he was currently experiencing.

The exact same expression that Khaslana now wore.

The creature was set in a violent fury, its decaying form thrashing and glitching around the screen as a trail of black cubes cast a shadowy void all around. Each time it moved, the cracks etched into its snow-white skin seemed to grow, and the golden blood was inverted to a deep purple hue. It was a complete amalgamation of its former glory, twisting a regal, angelic body into something more sinister. It almost reminded him of…

Phainon gasped between labored breaths, *"Mydei."*

His hands flew to support his partner, who already looked on the verge of collapsing. Phainon's skin was so hot to the touch, Mydei began to consider calling for an ambulance. How had a fever this high come on so suddenly with such little warning? If he didn't know any better, he would've thought Phainon had fallen into a boiling hot bath again.

Between his worrying, he happened to glance up at the monitor again, and a new window caught his eye. It read "■■■δ_me13■■Scepter■Shutdown■■" and a process was currently initiating below:

>■Deleting■■■43%■■

>■Del■et■ing■■58%■■■

>■D■el■etin■g■65■%■■■

>■■D■■e■le■ti■n■g■77■■%■

>■■■■■■■■89■%■

>■■■■■■■■99.99%■■■

>■Loading…■■■■■■■■■■

The number was frozen at 99.99% progress. It refused to advance, and the little virus continued to screech out in agony. The creature had reacted poorly when the entire computer was shut down before, but this 'deleting' process was only within a single program. Could it be, then, that Phainon had…?

“End it,” Phainon begged. His voice was incredibly weak, as if he were just barely holding on to consciousness. “Let go, Khaslana.”

If Mydei squinted, he could just barely glimpse the mouse pointer still clutched in the creature’s hands, as if it was still holding on to someone’s hand in its dying moments. That must be what was halting the process, then. It was Khaslana’s will to never let go.

The situation was far beyond his comprehension. But even so, Mydei knew what to do. Gently, he removed the mouse from Phainon’s hand and turned it off, just as he had before. The torrent of glitching masses surrounding the creature seemed to multiply exponentially as it wailed and tore at its hair with a pair of crumbling fists. If a computer program could feel emotion, then it was probably enduring an unbearable amount of torture from this deletion process.

“I’m sorry. It’ll be over soon,” Mydei soothed the two individuals beside him. His hands shook as he powered the mouse back on and quickly pressed the **PERMANENTLY DELETE** prompt in the middle of the screen. And Khaslana, in its final moments of anguish, slowly began to fade away in a cloud of darkened ash.

He let the dying creature hold his ‘hand’ as it disappeared. And then the screen blinked out to a vacant black space.

An ending like this could only throw Mydei’s heart into turmoil. What had even happened here? What had Phainon done, and just what did Khaslana’s reaction mean? He meant to ask the man about his intentions, but a solid *THUD!* upon the floor suspended his concern about the computer for now.

He called out, “Phainon!” but received no response. In the midst of his delirium, he’d fainted to the ground and fallen into a deep, unstirring sleep. His flesh was still heated to a concerning degree. It was time to get him some much-need medicine and rest, alright. And hopefully the situation wouldn’t worsen any more than it already had.

Mydei was still perfectly rigid in his bedside seat when Phainon opened his eyes that evening. His fever had mostly subsided and some color had been restored to his face, those sallow lines giving way to a healthier glow already. Even drenched in sweat and bruising around the eyes, he was beautiful.

He was typically the pinnacle of health, so the quick rebound wasn't too unexpected. Whatever this affliction was, it couldn't have been a typical illness. In all likelihood, it was some kind of stress-induced flareup that would be over with come morning.

"You're awake. Good." Mydei kept his tone civil, unwilling to place any further stress upon Phainon. No indication of a response was given, but he was willing to be patient. Whatever had occurred that afternoon had unsettled both of them, and they needed time to process everything.

He offered a water glass, which Phainon did not take, and then promptly lifted it to the man's lips without any room for argument. "Hydration is key to recovery. Drink up."

Phainon obeyed, leaning forward to steadily drain the glass until it was emptied. He managed a grateful half-smile and sank back down into the pillows, exhausted by even the smallest movement. Mydei would have been content to let him sleep through the night, but as he turned away, a shaky hand suddenly found his.

"Don't go," he rasped. "Please."

Under any other circumstances, Mydei would've been surprised by how direct his words were. Rarely did Phainon ever express his vulnerabilities outright, much less dare to seize anything for his own benefit. Even in shared moments of affection between them, he'd sooner force Mydei to pursue his own desires, letting go far too soon no matter how desperately he wanted to hold on. Now, though…

"Fine." Mydei didn't just remain in place, though. He sidled up to the opposite end of the bed and crawled in beside his partner, tugging him in close enough that his tousled hair fell in waves over Mydei's shoulder.

Strawberry-blonde and white strands mingled and intertwined across a shared pillow, just as their bodies melded together like perfect complements in their bed.

They would eventually breach the topic of what had truly occurred that evening. It was a conversation that could be put off but never dismissed, just as everything between them was. But all of that was better left for a day free of pain and confusion. Until they could come to terms with all the remaining heaviness lingering in the atmosphere, it was probably better to let it rest.

Just as always, Mydei fell into Phainon, into the golden sun seared on his skin that burned hotter than any distant star beyond the sky. *Titans, he was so warm.*

It was simple, existing beside him without needing anything else in return. This shared heat between them, undeniable proof of the life blooming within them, was more than enough.

Chapter 7: Epilogue - Eden

All throughout Phainon's life, he had the vague feeling that something, imperceptibly, was *wrong.* He remembered being five years old, wide-eyed, running through the comforting wheat fields of his hometown wielding a hoe as a sword. None of the villagers were well-off, but that year his parents had bought a brand new laptop to encourage his interest in the world beyond Aedes Elysiae. Cyrene's storybooks had already inspired something within him, and they made a pinky-promise to one day venture beyond the farthest mountains and trees together.

Maybe then, he'd be able to fill that hole within his heart.

The gift had excited him at first. He was a little less excited when he learned just how difficult using electronic devices could be. Coming from a traditional farming civilization mostly untouched by the outside world, few people in the village owned teleslates or computers, much less the newest models on the market. He couldn't read the user manual on his own either, so Phainon could only hope for the best as he tried to learn all its functions on his own.

Over time he became proficient in navigating the World Wound Web (after informing his parents that they needed to purchase a home router for browsing purposes) and successfully downloaded his first gaming application *NovaNymphs.* This was the origin of all his troubles, the very first heartbreak he'd experience as a child. Because only seven days later, he was met with the first of many error messages:

> **The following account has been suspended: Snowy496**

Needless to say, once he realized that his beloved virtual puppy was gone forever, Phainon cried and cried like never before.

“It’s not fair,” he blubbered into his mother’s blouse, smearing snot and tears everywhere. It really, *really* wasn’t. Even days later, after Phainon’s parents did everything within their power to cheer him up—excusing him from school, making his favorite honey suncakes with venison, letting him run around for an extra hour with Cyrene as they searched for fairies in the woods—a lingering feeling of unease remained within him.

Phainon didn’t think he did anything wrong. He may not have been that good with technology, but he tried his best to follow the rules: no talking to strangers online, no sharing his personal information, and no downloading any strange files. So why did it still end up this way? What went wrong along the way?

Many years later, in the aftermath of a grueling situation involving two infected computers, a sentient virus and a complete reconstructing of his perceived reality, the answers he once chased relentlessly finally appeared before him.

It’s just that…

Well. Now that the truth, or at least a part of it, had come to light, he felt more disconnected from his life than ever. And not in the same way when he was desperately running, hoping to find a shred of self-worth by throwing himself headfirst into work and neglecting his personal obligations until he was so winded they overtook him. One Phainon had come to terms with his own value to other people, he had easily fallen back into the roles of friend, student and lover. He no longer saw it as indulgence, but an integral part of his life that should not be discarded. That in itself was a huge hurdle to overcome, and only with patience and fiery tenacity did he finally make the leap.

Weeks before the vicious end of all rationality, upon discovering that his laptop had finally been restored to perfect working condition, he made the decision on his own to stop idling around waiting for a miracle to save him.

Phainon put in his two weeks’ notice that same morning, determined to leave behind an unsatisfying job and realign his life. His boss, Cerydra, was never impressed with his half-hearted dedication to the business, and

naturally she eyed him in that terrifying way no woman of her stature should ever be able to.

“Dearest disloyal subject, what do you plan to do now that you’ve plunged your sword deep into our hearts?”

Phainon frantically searched for the right words, hoping not to infuriate her any more than he already had. Fortunately, her partner decided to break the silence with a thoughtful hum of appreciation. “I think this sunfish was always destined for greater things beyond the world of salads, Cerydra.”

The woman relented at her words, more eager to please a lover’s fantasies than waste time arguing with an average minimum-wage employee who was ready to bolt. Phainon went through his remaining shifts with that question nagging incessantly in the back of his head.

What *did* he plan to do now? In truth, he never wanted anything in particular for himself. He never had any wishes, no long-lasting desires that he was willing to take hold of for his own gratification. The natural response within his heart was something along the lines of *I want to help people.* But such vague responses rarely moved others. So, he never answered.

After his final day of work, Phainon curled up in bed, breathing in the lingering traces left behind in one of Mydei’s old sweaters. More often than not he smelled like wood and citrus, along with the fragrance of old books that clung stubbornly at his skin. It wasn’t like the endless wheat fields and salty ocean breeze of his hometown, but something still familiar and comfortable. Something that was still undeniably home.

“I pretended to be strong on my own again just so you all wouldn’t worry. And look how well that’s done for me so far,” he confessed under the secrecy of his sheets, utterly alone in his apartment. “I don’t have a dream of my own yet.”

He went for a long, listless walk that same evening, taking in the sights of Okhema in early spring just as a passing traveler would. The difference rested in his memories associated with every street corner, temple, and

market stall. *That's our favorite café,* he'd think as the thick aroma of coffee beans wafted in his direction. *This is where Tribbie failed me for the fifth time during my practice driving exam. There's the bench where Castorice used to crochet and watch me play basketball.*

Hours into the night, as Phainon stepped out of the shadows and arrived at Theosphere Lake, the resounding silence seemed to consume him entirely. Dawncloud was largely an administrative district and cultural site, so its steep roads were practically deserted come the arrival of the Curtain Fall Hour. The refined stonework was always technically impressive to gaze upon, but it did little to stir something dormant within him now.

All Phainon could do was look up at the statue of Kephale the Worldbearer and drown in his misery as a steady rain began to fall overhead.

Coming back to Mydei was just as natural as breathing. That wasn't any problem he couldn't handle. What Phainon *didn't* know how to deal with was their little uninvited guest.

It was a computer virus taking on the form of an angel (not an elf or a fairy, obviously those were completely different), which in itself was so ironic he felt close to tears. Add in the fact that this *thing* was apparently responsible for every technological failing Phainon had experienced over the course of twenty years, and well—*no, of course he wasn't handling it well.*

Once they had become acquainted, it was easy to see that *he,* the creature, was a jealous little imp who had staked his own claim on Mydei despite Phainon's very clear territorial line already being mapped out in plain sight. *He* was always reaching for Mydei's hand, always messaging Mydei from Phainon's *TKQ* account, and monopolizing all of Mydei's time unfairly. Having already been deprived of time with his…partner, Phainon was already at his boiling point.

The worst of it came when the two of them were left alone. *He* refused to cooperate with Phainon, never answering any of his questions and just drifting off to sleep as if everything was uninteresting once Mydei went off

to work. Frustrated, Phainon stalked around the apartment searching for something more exciting to play with as the slow hours of the afternoon passed by.

It didn't take long to stumble upon the shiny carrying case Mydei had accidentally left in the kitchen that morning. Phainon wasn't usually the type to pry, but he recognized this as one of the cases Mydei reserved for transporting artifacts from the archives. Maybe there were treasures inside waiting for appraisal, he reasoned, and popped the silver lock open.

Origin of Primordial Chaos wasn't what he expected in the slightest. It was an unimpressive and thin tome, dressed in leather that had to be centuries old and carrying the stench of dust along with it. Its contents left him in a similar state of dissatisfaction; what was all this nonsense about divine offspring and the overwhelming veneration of Kephale? It was one thing to admire the titans, but this Kryptos was more of a cultist than a reliable source of holy wisdom.

The only thing that really stuck with him was that name—*Khaos.* It was oddly familiar. And so was the appearance of that character. For better or worse, all he could think about was the irritating little creature stuck behind the computer screen. So he returned to the office, started picking another fight with the fickle angel, and nearly lost himself in a strange fit of passionate rage he hadn't felt in quite some time.

He was already close to bursting. And then Mydei walked in, and called out, *"Khaslana,"* and something broke within him. The shattered glass on the floor was nothing in comparison to how his heart felt.

Why is he calling him *by that name? Why isn't it* me?

Learning that the computer virus that had been not-so-quietly haunting him for pretty much his entire life had also stolen his own name was just downright offensive. But what he felt at that moment wasn't just anger or hatred, no. It was *fear.* That was the response his brain had formulated on its own, and trying to make any sense of it was impossible. For some inexplicable reason, Phainon was *afraid* of the creature.

That feeling continued through the passing days in spite of his efforts to overcome it. He reread that lackluster novel and tried to connect the dots between the protagonist and this so-called “Khaslana,” but nothing seemed to fit cleanly. Countless theories floated around aimlessly in his mind:

Khaslana : Golden Blood

Golden Blood : Kephale

Kephale : Khaos

Conclusion: Kephale = Khaos = Khaslana?

That wasn’t going to cut it. And no matter how he probed Khaslana, tearing through thousands of web pages to capture the creature’s attention and possibly incite some level of communication between them, he never responded. Taunting the little angel was the only way he knew how to deal with his stress. He could feel his body growing weaker as time went on, but at the moment it only seemed to be the result of his tireless efforts. How could he have possibly known what was in store for him?

That café date with the art history group was supposed to be a relaxing, freeing experience for all of them. But once his memories were called into question, Phainon felt himself grow tired. He shut down Mydei’s arguments, wanting to leave the morning on a good note without the weight of his *wrongness* dragging the mood down. His energy continued to deplete as they walked home, and soon Phainon began to feel faint.

There was an itching in the back of his mind, a mystical sense that he had to get to the computer, he had to reach it before it was too late. So he sent Mydei away in search of a probably-nonexistent article of clothing that had gotten mixed up in all his mismatched memories.

The room was blinding when he stepped inside. Khaslana was waiting for him there, wrapped in a strange golden shell resembling an egg or cocoon. Phainon reached a trembling hand forward and touched the screen, knowing

that his touch could never be felt. And yet, that action seemed to make it all the more real.

“I’m going to override you now,” Phainon promised the creature as his mouse pointer hovered over the new **uninstall** prompt onscreen. A mass of chaotic matter surrounded Khaslana in an instant, and Phainon’s head throbbed with an excruciating pain just as a distant alarm began to ring out.

He was no longer himself. He was…

Mydei’s hands were always soft and warm, but they had turned to ice against his sweltering skin. Whatever words spilled from his mouth in the following moments weren’t his own. They came from *him—the other him.* And then, with the breath completely knocked from his lungs, he plummeted face-first upon the earth.

Phainon appreciated Mydei’s patience with him after this entire mess finally started to fade away, he really did. Titans knew how the man still put up with him after all this time. Before, Mydei had outright told Phainon about his desire to talk about all their issues rather than bottling everything up to the point of exploding, and the sentiment was shared between them. But finding the right words to express every single emotion pounding away within his brain.

How could I ever tell you the truth? He wondered day in and out, trying to come to terms with his own uselessness. It was a truth too heavy for even Phainon to bear; those strange, nonexistent memories only came to him in shattered fragments now, as if his mind was trying to shield him. Logically, he knew that Mydei would be able to handle it. The man was headstrong beyond words and, somehow, also bore certain recollections of the past that he shouldn’t have been able to.

Still, none of that changed the basis of his predicament. Sometimes Phainon would talk to the mirror in the middle of the night, searching for any remaining trace of golden blood upon his skin. But it would always reflect

back flawlessly, no longer the face of a burning idol, but that of a normal young man with a normal life.

“This is everything you wanted, you know,” Phainon reprimanded himself as he covered an eye with the hood of his black pullover. And it was, really. But even as the dark circles began to fade and his energy slowly recovered, he was still at a loss for what to do with himself. Could he even live with the weight of an immutable past constantly dragging him down?

One day he sat before his laptop, head in hands, trying his best to not fall apart in the face of something so mundane as his WovenIn profile.

“I can do just about anything I set my mind to, so a rewarding career is never too far out of reach!” He tried to encourage himself, scrolling through the recent job listings for the nth time that month.

“Hmm…let’s see. Local postings only, nothing too far off from Okhema. Commuting is a hassle when you only have two wheels. Oh, and it can’t be minimum wage anymore. It’s exhausting being the only money-strapped person in an otherwise wealthy friend group.” Well, Cipher excluded. She preferred to shirk Aglaea’s comfortable fortune for her own wiles. He groaned, “Only forty results? In all of Okhema? I didn’t think the economy was this bad!”

He’d once lived through the end of the world thirty million times over, and it really couldn’t get any worse than that. It’s hard to believe he once lost his mind working a minimum-wage job at a salad bar.

“Florist…online gaming technical support…head chef…librarian. Ugh, I’m definitely not qualified for any of these. Oh, a customer representative—for the IPC’s Marketing Development Department? No thanks.”

None of these jobs were really rewarding, though. Once upon a time in a completely different age he had been a hero, so the goal of helping people was completely ingrained in his soul. The phantom scars of the past were all but forgotten to Amphoreus now, but there was always someone out there who needed saving. Even if his efforts proved futile over and over again, Phainon was never the type to relent to fate.

He had lived a good life this time around. Quiet, unassuming, comfortable, and full of such overwhelming love he'd never fully be able to comprehend. It was funny to think he'd once been denoted as nothing more than an entity of pure hatred and rage. Those feelings were more prevalent once the memories of the past merged with him, but the ability to be a *real, living person* was freeing.

Thinking more about the precious experiences of this lifetime, one thing did come to mind. He murmured to himself, "Teaching wouldn't be half bad. When I was little, I always assumed I'd take over for Mrs. Pythias one day. Obviously that didn't end up working out, but there will always be people to teach somewhere."

He drew a hand over his face, trying to contain the small smile threatening to break through. No use in getting too excited this early on. Besides…

"Going back to school would be a bit of a drag though. Professor Anaxa's already more than exhausted of me by now. At least Aglaea would write a thorough recommendation letter if I asked." Phainon absently played with the strings of his hoodie. "What would I even teach anyway? Art history? Would people really pay to learn from me?"

He could almost see it now: all the pains of coming up with lesson plans, wanting to pull out his hair at every incorrectly cited source on students' papers, sleepless nights where he almost dreaded having to face the people he vowed to instruct. It wasn't an easy career to pursue by any means, and Phainon lacked the self-esteem to have any faith in his own abilities.

However, just as clearly, another vision came into view; his everyday life with Mydei. It was their café dates, mornings spent analyzing ancient artifacts over tea and honeycakes, spending the afternoon away before coming back home to the warm embrace of his person.

Inevitably, Phainon spent much of his time fantasizing about the unattainable life he'd always dreamed of having. And now that he was in the midst of living it, he had a difficult time accepting that it was, in fact, real.

Was it even plausible? Would Mydei want the same thing as him? Their relationship had always been all over the place, whether he considered all the countless lifetimes of bloodshed or the repression that silenced both of them in this new world. All the time they spent together was proof enough of Mydei's commitment to him, but he couldn't help but doubt himself anyway.

Was he even cut out for this? It wasn't that Phainon was unused to wanting things. He was only human, after all. But when it came to actually pursuing those wants? He wasn't so good at following through. He was always better at making other people happy. Coming to Okhema was Cyrene's idea in the first place. He just tagged along. And he definitely never meant to settle down here—but who ever prepares themself for love?

At the end of the day, whatever Phainon decided, failure was never an option for him. He would commit to his cause without faltering even once.

The day he finally began to open up to Mydei was also the day he decided to unveil the fruits of his second high-priority project. It was already well into the Month of Everday when his secret commission was completed, and Phainon was all-too enthusiastic to show it off the minute it fell into his hands.

"This is…" Mydei's voice wavered as he stared in disbelief at the computer screen. It was a familiar expression, all slack in the jaw and with eyes blown up like a bug's. Phainon just laughed and nudged him forward to grab the mouse.

There, hovering on the screen, was another very familiar face. Two pairs of golden eyes interlocked as if they had never been apart. Phainon, now considering himself to be in-tune with his emotions, didn't bother with envy this time. He just happily exclaimed, "Your brand new desktop assistant—Khaslana! Subscription and spyware-free, of course. It's really just a harmless little guy."

"You made this?"

Phainon scoffed. Him, doing anything related to technology? Whatever his natural prowess for data may have been in an era long past was obviously no more in this world. "Not on my own. You may recall that I'm not exactly the most tech-savvy person out there, so I commissioned one of Castorice's online friends who's a game developer. All I did was send over the references for his model and animations."

Then, smiling once again, he added, "Truthfully, I knew how fond you'd grown of your little friend. It must be a little lonely when I'm not around, so I wanted to make sure you were always in good company."

Was that a self-compliment? It's not like Mydei would know even if it was. But as if sensing something was amiss, the man turned to scrutinize him with fiercely focused eyes. "And exactly how much did you spend on this little project?"

Ah. He was done for. "...Only about 7500 credits. Plus a 1000 credit tip."

"Phainon, will you ever stop wasting your money on trinkets?" Rude, rude Mydei. How ungrateful could he be?

Phainon retorted, "They're antiques, not just some dollar store junk! And neither is Khaslana!" He leaned close to the screen, flashing his most pleading expression Mydei's way. "How can you look into those big, beautiful eyes and call him *useless?"*

Khaslana's eyes were indeed far more full of life now that he was just an average virtual assistant instead of a piece of malware simmering inside his hard drive. As if sensing Phainon's desire for attention, Khaslana instantly

summoned Bubbles the Chimera from the void and let the little pet drop onto his spiky hair. He blinked and looked around innocently, swaying under the creature’s weight before smiling slightly.

“...You're both using the chimeras against me now?”

“It's fair game. See, you're already smiling more. I knew you wouldn't be able to resist him!” Mydei’s gorgeous smile was a sight to behold. He’d been expressing his happiness more openly ever since they had reconciled, and Phainon had already vowed to never forsake his trust again.

Mydei sighed, letting go of his concerns to fully appreciate this act of kindness. “Although I question your common sense sometimes, I know you're always genuine. So…thank you.”

Phainon just grinned in return before turning back to the screen, chiming, “Look, Khaslana sent you a message!”

Khaslana: I grant you a dawn where all spam mail burns to ash!

“He's surprisingly diligent.”

“Right?” Phainon practically had stars in his eyes. Mydei had once told him how fortunate he felt to have Phainon in his life, how he always felt incredibly warm around him, like a gentle ray of sunlight had descended upon him from beyond the depths of the evernight. He’d once felt conflicted about those words, never knowing how to reply without being consumed by his predecessor’s grief. Now, though, it was starting to feel straightforward enough.

He knew just what to say when Mydei later asked him that question, “Don't you ever want to see the worlds beyond?”

A smirk rose on Phainon’s lips, playful enough as he stroked at Mydei’s jawline. “No need. You already know how to take me to the stars and back

whenever I want."

"Always so crass." Still, it earned him a half-satisfied sigh that set his heart at ease.

Mydei always seemed half-convinced that he was ready to bolt at any given moment, taking off in a rocket ship until their world was just a speck of dust in the corner of his eye. It was stupid; sure, it was interesting to learn about other worlds, but what could Phainon possibly gain from leaving? Before those memories were passed onto him, he didn't really think about outer space often, aside from treating it as some vague unknown.

It was just like Amphoreus' past, in a way. Phainon always knew in his heart that the truth was out there somewhere, sailing around in the swirling river of time like a drift bottle. He never thought he would be the one to uncover it, though. It didn't seem possible for someone like him to achieve much of anything.

He was just a nobody who worked at a local food chain and hadn't put his art history degree to any use. It was just collecting dust on a shelf next to those paper tarot cards he and Cyrene had made as kids. Fate, it seemed, was never aligned in his favor.

Now, though—*now.* Even with mere fragments of the past clutched in his freshly cleaned hands, he recognized that this was his perfect second chance. It wasn't an unending redo of days past in a cycle of violence and flames anymore, but a complete restarting of their lives. Now, he had the chance to do what he had always secretly desired, say what words were always fighting to remain buried beneath the surface.

He didn't need to go anywhere else to become a so-called hero. In a way, everything he'd ever desired was already within reach. The dream of tomorrow, of carrying everyone else's dreams on to a world free of suffering, was nearly complete. There was only one thing he had left to achieve—a simple wish to stand face to face, free of all masks and no longer held back by the cruelty of the past.

So without any restraints to bind him, Phainon leaned ever closer.

“Mydeimos…” his breath was hot against the shell of his ear. “I really do love you.”

And gods above, did Mydei already know. It was whispered on rare occasions of indulgence as he was lost in a slightly-drunken revelry of unending joy, or during the heights of passion when they were completely unleashed and no longer thinking straight, or in the early hours of the morning when the only words he could manage were against that birthmark in the middle of Mydei’s back.

It was in every unspoken word, every time his eyes dripped with unbridled affection, and every time their lips bloomed into a perfect pair. It was everywhere, spreading all throughout his life.

And he simply said, “I love you, too,” before they shared in an embrace that would never end.

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